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during the CJP-led demonstration earlier this week. The clashes left several protesters and police personnel injured, prompting multiple FIRs and an ongoing investigation into the incident. Delhi Police appealed to the public to rely only on official sources for updates and refrain from sharing unverified claims on social media.

The growing footprint of the agitation has also led to logistical challenges. With protesters spread across multiple locations, announcements from the main stage often fail to reach those stationed farther away.

During a visit to the protest site on Wednesday night, *The Pioneer* observed fresh groups continuing to arrive at Jantar Mantar, while smaller clusters at different points raised slogans independently, many seemingly unaware of the speeches and announcements being made from the central stage.

What Thursday added to the agitation was a visual dimension that no organiser planned, and no government directive can easily counter. When a protest begins producing its own iconography drawn from Marvel comics and *Game of Thrones*, when a student from Agra takes the time to procure a full Spider-Man costume and travel to Delhi in it, when another student decides that wearing the Hulk mask and sweeping the ground is the most meaningful contribution he can make, something has shifted in how young people are processing both their anger and their investment in the cause.

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is to inform to all concerned that Sh. Chhaya Lal S/o Sh. Mukund Lal Dayma R/o C-116, Sector-2, Noida U.P. who is the original owner/allottee of Residential Plot No. 6, Block-B, Sector-92, Noida U.P., Sh. Kanhaiya Lal expired on dt. 14.06.2011.

The WILL was executed in favour of Smt. Rukmani Damaia alias Rukmani Dayma W/o Sh. Hari Singh Dayma R/o 115, Nandpur, Haripur, Rajasthan, which is registered in Sub-Registrar 1st, Noida, Dt. 09.01.2002.

It is informed to all concern that the said Property Residential Plot No. 6, Block-B, Sector-92, Noida, is going to be transferred in favour of Smt. Rukmani Damaia alias Rukmani Dayma W/o Sh. Hari Singh Dayma R/o 115, Nandpur, Haripur, Rajasthan, if anyone has/have any objection he/she may file his/her objection alongwith the sufficient proof in the Residential Plot Department of the Noida Authority within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice.

Smt. Rukmani Dayma

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is to inform to the public at large that Mr. Kunal Malik had acquired Flat bearing No.A-20, at 2nd Floor B-3rd Floor, G+H-L-G, Duplex, at Laxmi Kunj C.G.H.S Ltd. on Plot No. 6, Sector-13,Rohini New Delhi-85 vide Relinquishment Deed dt. 11.02.2015 after the death of her husband Mr. Rajinder K Malik, who died intestate after leaving Mrs. Monika Khanna, Mr. Ranjan Malik and Mrs. Isha Malik as his only legal heirs. Apart from above Lr's there is / are no other Legal heir/s. Now Mrs. Kunal Malik is the undisputed owner of said property and willing to mortgage the said property with IndusInd Bank Ltd.

OR

Any person / firm / institution / company having any claim or right in respect of the said property by way of inheritance, share, sale, agreement, lease, license, gift, possession, legal heirs, partners or encumbrance howsoever or otherwise is hereby required to intimate in writing to the undersigned within 07 days from the date of publication of this notice of his/her their share or claim, if any, with all supporting documents at below mentioned address. After expiration of notice period, the claims, if any, of such persons shall be treated null and void and also treated as waived and not binding on our client.

**Ajay Kumar Giri (Advocate) H. No. 26/161, Basement,
Vikram Vihar, Lajpat Nagar 4, New Delhi - 110024**

PUBLIC NOTICE

The original deeds 9454/9455 dated 14.10.1977 & 324 dated 01.05.2002 possession letter and allotment letter of my house located at SB 117 Shastri Nagar, Ghaziabad, belonging to Vijay Pal Singh have been lost somewhere. Unauthorised use of these will be illegal. Please inform me if you find them.

Pramod Kumar Singh S/o- Arjun Singh R/o- SB 11, Shastri Nagar, Ghaziabad, M.O. 9560157779

THE MANAGEMENT COMMITTEE OF VIKAS COOPERATIVE GROUP HOUSING SOCIETY West Enclave Pitampura, New Delhi-110034

is going to forward the name of

- Mrs Komal M. No. 05
- Mrs Vinod Kumar M. No. 17

To register cooperative Societies for the allotment of MIG Flats in the above society. If anybody has any objection he/she can raise and sustain by writing to Hony. president of the society within 7 days from the date of publishing of this notice.

Sh. Mohan Lal Joshi

पंजाब नेशनल बैंक

..... सर्वो का प्रमुख

(A GOVERNMENT OF INDIA UNDERTAKING)

ASSET RECOVERY MANAGEMENT BRANCH, SOUTH DELHI

4 th Floor, 7 PNB House, Bhikaji Cama Place, New Delhi - 110066.

POSSESSION NOTICE

(Under Section-13(4) of Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with rule 8(I) of Security Interest & Enforcement Rules 2002 (for Immovable Property))

Whereas, the undersigned being the Authorized Officer of the Punjab National Bank, Punjab National Bank, Asset Recovery Management Branch 4 th Floor, 7 PNB House, Bhikaji Cama Place, New Delhi - 110066 under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets & Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 [herein after referred to as the "said act"] and in exercise of powers conferred under Section 13 read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002, issued demand notice dated 14.05.2026 calling upon the borrower (1.) **M/s Jain Graha Udyog Private Limited, At:- A-320, 3 rd Floor, Ansal Chamber - 1, Bhikaji Cama Place, New Delhi – 110066 Also At:- 39 Mission Compound Road Saharanpur, Uttar Pradesh – 274001** 2. **M. Rupak Kumar (Director & Guarantor) At:- H.No. 924 Flat No. 204 Second Floor, Block -C2 Palm Vihar VTC – Choma (62), Gurgaon – 122017** Hayana (3) **Mr. Vikrant Sharma (Director & Guarantor) At:- E-1408 Near Mani Ki Tiadi Nil Faridabad Dubau Colony, Faridabad – 121001** Hayana (4) **Mr. Ashvini Kumar Malik (Guarantor) At:- C-63, 1st Floor Triantail East New Delhi – 110065** (5) **Mrs. Pooja (Guarantor) At:- 1728 M-Block Gali No – 7 Vijay Enclave, Darbh South West Delhi – 110045** (6) **Mrs. Preksha Jain (Guarantor) At:- 39 Mission Compound Saharanpur Uttar Pradesh - 274001 as detailed below:-**

Credit Facility	Sanctioned Amount	Balance Outstanding as on NPA date 06.10.2025 (Excluding Interest and Charges)	Total Outstanding as on 30.04.2026 (Excluding Future Interest, Cost and Charges)
Overdraft	Rs. 4,50,00,000/-	Rs. 6,42,70,771.63	Rs. 7,67,53,346.23
Bank Guarantee	Rs. 5,00,00,000/-	Rs. 1,99,55,000.00	Rs. 2,80,00,000
Total	Rs. 9,50,00,000/-	Rs. 8,42,25,771.63	Rs. 7,70,33,346.23

to repay the amount as mentioned in the notice being Rs. 7,70,33,346.23/- (Rupees Seven Crore Seventy Lakhs Thirty-Three Thousand Three Hundred Forty-Six & Paise Twenty-Three Only) as on 30.04.2026 with further interest at contracted rate, incidental expenses, cost, charges etc. until payment in full within 60 days from the date of notice (s) / date of receipt of the said notice(s).

The Borrower/Guarantor/Mortgagor having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken Symbolic Possession of the properties described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him under Sub-section (4) of Section 13 of Act read with Rule 8 of the security Interest Enforcement Rules, 2002 on this **22nd day of July of the year 2026.**

The Borrower/Guarantor/Mortgagor in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the property mentioned here under and any dealing with the said property will be subject to the charge of Punjab National Bank, Punjab National Bank, Asset Recovery Management Branch 4 th Floor, 7 PNB House, Bhikaji Cama Place, New Delhi – 110066 for an amount as detailed below: -

Credit Facility	Sanctioned Amount	Balance Outstanding as on NPA date 06.10.2025 (Excluding Interest and Charges)	Total Outstanding as on 30.04.2026 (Excluding Future Interest, Cost and Charges)
Overdraft	Rs. 4,50,00,000/-	Rs. 6,42,70,771.63	Rs. 7,67,53,346.23
Bank Guarantee	Rs. 5,00,00,000/-	Rs. 1,99,55,000.00	Rs. 2,80,00,000
Total	Rs. 9,50,00,000/-	Rs. 8,42,25,771.63	Rs. 7,70,33,346.23

Due and outstanding an amount of Rs. 7,70,33,346.23/- (Rupees Seven Crore Seventy Lakhs Thirty-Three Thousand Three Hundred Forty-Six & Paise Twenty-Three Only) as on 30.04.2026 with further interest at the contracted rate, incidental expenses, charges, costs etc.

The Borrowers, Guarantors, mortgagors attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of section 13 of the Act in respect of time available to redeem the secured assets.

DESCRIPTION OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTIES:-

Commercial Unit No. – C-G-05 on Ground Floor, Super Area 6754 Sq. Fts. (627.46 Sq. Mtrs.) in Commercial Building Known as Urban Square at Village Ghata, Sector-62, Golf Course Extension Road, Gurugah, Haryana.

Date:22.07.2026 Place: New Delhi

Authorized Officer, Punjab National Bank

REGARDS HONARY PRESIDENT

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the General Public that Mr. Brijesh Devi is the owner of the Residential House/Plot No. 228, area measuring 86.94 Sq. Mtrs., i.e., 104 Sq. Yds., out of Gata No. 685, situated in the area of Village Janokhar, Tehsil and District Meerut, U.P. The Same is owned by Gift Deed dated 25.05.2026, Executed by Mr. Deshranj S/o Mr. Charan Singh In favour of Mrs. Brijesh Devi W/o Deshranj, U.P. The same is registered in the office of Sub Registrar, Meerut, U.P. No. 6580, in Book No. 1, Vol. No. 17018, on Pages No. 259-276, That All Persons are requested that Mrs. Brijesh Devi, Mr. Deshranj Kumar, and Mr. Deshranj are mortgaging the said property with ARJ Housing Finance (India) Limited, General public hereby informed that any Person or corporate company, financial institution & others has any claim/charge/interest/title in the said property or any document/instrument relating to the said property written on the below mentioned address within 7 days of the present Rohit Kumar Advocate Medhaswani Enforcement & Legal Service 329, Aditya Palace Garh Road Meerut U.P 20004, Mob.no: 7306061626, 981771626 Email: medhaswinenforcement@gmail.com

केनरा बैंक Canara Bank

Regional Office, West Delhi

Invitation for Applications – Financial Literacy Counsellor (Contract Basis)

Canara Bank, Regional Office West Delhi, invites applications from eligible candidates for engagement as Financial Literacy Counsellor (FLC) on a contract basis. Eligibility : Graduate from a recognized University, Age below 62 years., Knowledge of Banking operations, Awareness of Government Social Security Schemes., Ability to conduct Financial Literacy Camps, awareness programmers, and village visits. Retired Bank Officials will be preferred. Engagement & Remuneration : Contract Period: 3 Years, number of Vacancy:1 Monthly Remuneration : Rs. 24,138. Conveyance Allowance : Rs. 3,600 per month Subject to the Bank's terms and conditions.

How to Apply: Applications should reach: The Deputy General Manager, Canara Bank, Regional Office West Delhi 2nd Floor, Community Centre, 18 G, DDA Vikaspur, New Delhi – 110018 E-mail: frowdel@canarabank.com Last Date for Submission: 31 July 2026

For application format and further details, contact: Sri Ashok Kumar Srivastava Mobile: 8752021623

Deputy General Manager

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



Delhi Police Inspector Nand Kishore Singh, who was injured in an alleged assault while heading for duty near Jantar Mantar in New Delhi PT

“There were around 4,000



Special CP Crime Devesh Chandra Srivastava meets an injured policeman getting treatment at the Ram Manohar Lohia Hospital in New Delhi

assaulted me with lathis, sticks, stones and whatever sharp objects they had in their hands. I somehow managed to escape. I was in uniform when they attacked

In a separate incident, Delhi Police also registered an FIR after protesters allegedly assaulted two Rapid Action Force (RAF) personnel at the Tolstoy Marg-Parliament Street intersection. A 35-second video circulating online shows one RAF officer falling to the ground before being kicked and punched by members of

Meanwhile, CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke denied that protesters were responsible for the violence, alleging that outsiders had infiltrated the demonstration to defame the month-long agitation.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In its statement, Delhi Police said, "... it is clarified that the said order is a routine extension/renewal of powers under the NSA, which is issued every three months." It added that the present renewal had been approved on July 7 for the period between July 19 and October 18, before the CJP protests began. "It is further clarified that no specific request was made in the present context. The renewal is a routine administrative exercise and has been interpreted out of context by certain media reports," the statement said.

KHUSHI MEHROTRA
 ■ New Delhi

The traders' body cited the "critical situation" around Connaught Place due to the ongoing protest and urged establishments to

The restrictions also disrupted daily life for thousands of commuters and office-goers across central



Security arrangements have been increased as students begin gathering at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi

Commuters reported taking longer, circuitous routes to reach offices and other destinations, while many employees said they were stranded due to the sudden closures. Several also complained of spending significantly more on taxis, auto-rickshaws and app-based

The heightened deployment follows violent clashes that erupted during the CIP's

Security officials remained on high alert throughout Thursday as authorities sought to prevent any fresh outbreak of violence while allowing the protest to continue under close surveillance.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi

Superheroes turned up at protest sites in different cities. Protesters cosplayed as Batman, Spider-Man, Superman, and Iron Man. Mahatma Gandhi and B.R. Ambedkar were, in the language of the internet, revived for the latest season." The history and the meme lived in the same frame.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
 New Delhi

Delhi Education Minister Ashish Sood said that paper leaks have happened over the years without any course correction, but the Modi government "ended it".

Actual Photograph: Narela

IN FOCUS



Students Federation of India (SFI) members stage a protest demanding the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan at Chachal ground in Guwahati on Thursday

Akhilesh slams Centre over student protests in Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav on Thursday accused the Centre of functioning with arrogance instead of democratic values and said pressure on the student protesters will not work, urging the government to admit its "mistake" and start dialogue.

He also took swipe at the BJP government, claiming its understanding of "accountability" refers to the "ability to fill accounts" in the context of the ongoing probe into the alleged ram temple donation theft.



Talking to reporters at the Lucknow airport after returning from New Delhi, Yadav accused the BJP governments at the Centre and in Uttar Pradesh of failing to ensure fair examinations.

He further said repeated paper leaks had jeopardised the future of lakhs of students and claimed the government itself had acknowledged irregularities by conducting the (NEET) re-examination.

"The matter is absolutely clear. The government should accept the demands of students and youth. The minister himself admitted that there were irregularities in the (NEET) examination and that the paper was leaked. That is why the examination

had to be conducted again," Yadav said. He alleged that the re-examination was proof that the authorities had failed to conduct the test fairly.

"I don't know how many children's futures have been jeopardised. Paper leaks are not happening for the first time. There seems to be a competition between the Government of India and the Uttar Pradesh government over who can have more paper leaks," Yadav said.

Claiming that paper leaks were being orchestrated rather than occurring accidentally, the former Uttar Pradesh chief minister said, "These papers are not merely



getting leaked, they are being made to leak so that students do not get jobs. Along with employment, the issue of reservation is also linked.

Yadav said the Samajwadi Party would continue to raise the issue in the legislature until the Union education minister resigned.

"We will continue to raise our voice in the House until the minister resigns. The demands of the families of those children who lost their lives should also be accepted," he said.

Asked about the government's refusal to concede the protesters' demands, Yadav accused it of functioning with arrogance instead of democratic values.

Delhi Police maintain vigil at ongoing CJP protest

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Delhi Police say they do not plan to take action against the ongoing Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) protest at Jantar Mantar right now. Security remains tight as the protest, now in its month, continues.

Delhi Police took to X to debunk the rumours floating on social media platforms. "There is no plan of Delhi police to crack down on the ongoing protest tonight, as is being conveyed. You are advised to refrain from spreading or circulating any misleading/unverified information".

The youth-led movement began online as a satirical reaction to remarks about unemployed youth and has grown into a large protest over alleged exam paper leaks, including the NEET controversy, as well as broader problems in the education system.

Students, parents, and other supporters have been protesting at Jantar Mantar since mid-June, and the protest has now entered its second month. Police say they are handling the demonstration professionally at the approved protest site. On July 20, when protesters tried to march toward Parliament, clashes broke out, and both sides were injured as police used force and tear gas.



Delhi Police personnel in protective gear stand guard at Jantar Mantar during the ongoing protest in New Delhi on Thursday

The sit-in is continuing under close watch. Security steps include barricades, a strong police presence, temporary internet restrictions near the protest, and the closure of nearby metro stations and shops in Connaught Place to keep order. Police have filed FIRs for earlier stone-pelting and attacks on officers, and they have warned people not to spread false information, like fake reports of protester deaths.

There has not been any order yet to remove or break up the main group at Jantar Mantar. Officials say they are

handling the protests within the law and are working to prevent things from getting out of control or to stop unauthorised marches. CJP leaders, including founder Abhijeet Dipke, say the protest will go on until their main demand for accountability is met.

Climate activist Sonam Wangchuk is still taking part, although some people are worried about his health. The standoff has highlighted ongoing debates about exam fairness, youth frustration, and how to balance the right to protest with keeping order in Delhi.

Ram Mandir opponents giving sermons is laughable: CM Yogi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gorakhpur (UP)

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Thursday, hinting at the Samajwadi Party, said it is laughable that those who went to court against Ram Mandir's construction are now giving sermons on faith. Adityanath made the remark after he inaugurated or laid the foundation of 14 development projects worth over ₹995 crore for his constituency, Gorakhpur Urban.

"Before 2017, riots were normal, anarchy was at its peak. Just recall how riots would break out during Holi, Vijayadashami, Durga Puja, and Ram Navami. They would not allow Janmashami celebrations or the Kanwar Yatra to take place." "In short, those who used to attack matters of faith back then have now taken it upon themselves to pose as the greatest champions of that very faith," the BJP leader said.

"Those who created obstacles in the path of the Ram Janmabhoomi temple's construction, who fired upon devotees of Lord Ram during the Ram Janmabhoomi movement, who deployed their lawyers in the Supreme Court to oppose the temple, those very people are speaking about faith today," he



UP CM Yogi Adityanath during the inauguration and foundation stone laying program for development projects in Gorakhpur

added. Adityanath said that the same people who used to play with faith and the future of the youth are now delivering grand speeches. "Their sermons seem laughable."

The chief minister said that ten years ago, before he came to power in the state, people used to be afraid of coming to Gorakhpur because of the mafia and mosquitoes.

"Where there are mosquitoes, there is malaria, dengue, encephalitis; and because of the mafia, no one would even buy property here. Today, however, buying land and building a house in Gorakhpur is everyone's top choice," he said.

Adityanath claimed that no one was willing to invest in the Gorakhpur Industrial Development Authority till he took over the reins of the

state and the constituency. He also blamed the Samajwadi Party, Bahujan Samaj Party, and the Congress Governments for the closure of 29 sugar mills in the State.

"They also sold off 21 of them at throwaway prices. The Padrauna sugar mill, for instance, was sold for a mere ₹2 crore, a fraction of its true value. The land alone was worth around ₹200 crore," he said. The BJP leader alleged that under the past Governments, there existed a 'constable syndicate' which controlled all recruitment.

"Today, I can say that jobs are available and selections are made without undue influence; whether it is recruitment for the UP Police, the teaching profession, or positions like sub-divisional magistrate or deputy SP," he said.

Govt bars communication infra providers from sharing data outside India

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Government has barred communication infrastructure providers, including those involved in cloud-based networks for telecom services, mobile towers and satellite gateways, from sharing any data outside the country, according to an official notification.

The Department of Telecom, in a notification for the authorisation framework for infrastructure providers, has made it mandatory that entire telecommunication data should be stored within the country.

"Every new authorised entity shall ensure that all systems of its telecommunication network and the data, logs and information associated with its telecommunication network shall be stored within India and no copies of such data, logs and information shall be routed, shared or made available outside India," the notification dated July 20 said.

Authorisation frameworks are part of Government strategy to shift from licensing regime to light regulation as per the Telecommunications Act 2023. Infrastructure provider, digital connectivity infrastructure provider, internet exchange point provider, satellite earth

17 Delhi metro stations to remain shut for 3rd day

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Seventeen metro stations in central Delhi will remain closed on Friday, marking the third consecutive day of closure, in the wake of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) protest at Jantar Mantar.

The Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) said late on Thursday that the stations will remain closed from 7.30 am on Friday until further instructions, citing security reasons.

The stations to remain shut are Lok Kalyan Marg, Rajiv Chowk, Patel Chowk, Ramakrishna Ashram Marg, Barakhambha Road, Supreme Court, Seva Teerth, Janpath, Mandi House, Central Secretariat, ITO, Delhi Gate, Indraprastha, Khan Market, Jor Bagh, Shivaji Stadium and Jhandewalan. The DMRC said interchange facilities will be available at Rajiv Chowk, Mandi House and Central Secretariat stations.

The very same stations remained closed for prolonged periods on Wednesday and Thursday due to security arrangements linked to the protest, causing inconvenience to office-



goers, students and other commuters in central Delhi.

On Thursday, entry gates of three stations — Central Secretariat, Mandi house and Rajiv Chowk — was opened late evening after around 14 hours of closure, while remaining stations remain closed. Many passengers had to alter their travel plans, switch to alternate routes or rely on road transport amid heavy traffic congestion.

Earlier, five metro stations — Janpath, Rajiv Chowk, Patel Chowk, Central Secretariat and Seva Teerth — were closed for several hours on Monday as security was tightened in view of the protest.

The repeated closures have disrupted daily commuting in the capital's central districts, with traffic restrictions around Janpath, Jantar Mantar and adjoining areas adding to delays during peak hours.

station gateway, cloud-hosted telecommunication network provider and mobile number portability provider at national level can seek authorisation under the notified framework.

Under the new norms, the Centre for the purposes of monitoring compliance with the rules may access and inspect the sites where telecommunication equipment and network are established, "including within a user's premises",

agency to audit processes or systems established by the authorised entity.

The notification said that the designated agency will not collect nor require the disclosure of any information, the disclosure of which may harm the competitive position of any user or the new authorised entity.

Infrastructure providers under the new framework will be solely responsible for obtaining permission to roll out the network and any delay in such permission



audit processes or systems established by such new authorised entity for compliance of these rules and even may serve no notice if the government considers that immediate action is necessary or expedient in public interest.

For monitoring compliance, the centre may appoint a designated

should not be a reason for non-compliance of any rules under the new framework.

"The non-availability of right of way or delays in obtaining right of way permission by the new authorised entity shall not be a cause or ground for non-compliance with any obligations under these rules," the framework said.

Police plan Passport curbs in stir violence...

While criminal cases can take a long time and may not always lead to punishment, restricting travel makes it personally costly to join in violence and shows that the State will act beyond just jail time.

Delhi Police have filed several FIRs for rioting, assaulting public servants, and damaging public property in relation to the violence on Monday. Investigations are still underway, with police using video footage and other evidence to identify those involved. Sources allege anti-social elements and criminals joined the gathering.

"In the coming weeks, the process of identifying people, making recommendations, and possible legal challenges will show if this approach is fair or too harsh. The violence on 20 July was real, so the state's response needs to be both strong and careful", a source said. Once people are clearly linked to the violence, police will recommend that their passports be cancelled under the Passports Act, 1967, they said.

Section 10 of the Act empowers the passport authority to impound or revoke a travel document if the holder has been convicted of an offence involving moral turpitude and sentenced to imprisonment of two years or more, or in cases where the holder's continued possession is deemed prejudicial to the sovereignty, integrity or security of India. Pending criminal proceedings can also complicate renewal or fresh issuance under Section 6.

While courts have clarified that mere pendency does not automatically bar a passport, a formal recommendation from police following identification in rioting cases carries weight, significantly restricting international travel.

"Protesters held ongoing sit-ins at Jantar Mantar, calling for Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan to resign and for major reforms. Peaceful protest is a constitutional right. But when protests reach the security area around Parliament, the state also

has a clear duty to keep order," a source said.

The passport measure is a deterrent, turning a local law-and-order issue into one with national and international effects.

Gujarat ATS nets 13 alleged JeM suspects

Officials allege the suspects were active JeM members who helped build a support network, arranged logistics and shelter, recruited others, and spread extremist ideas. Several of the suspects had ties to a madrasa in Patan, where they had stayed since 2023.

Deputy Inspector General of ATS, Sunil Joshi, said that teams worked with police in Gujarat and Rajasthan to identify additional suspects using witness statements and electronic data. The five most recent suspects are now in police custody for further questioning. The investigation is still looking into possible targets, funding, and others who may be involved.

The group, officials allege, received about ₹3 lakh to buy a used car and rent a hideout. Investigators claim they found over 250 pieces of jihadi literature, including Gujarati translations of works by JeM founder Masood Azhar and letters to him. They also claim to have found materials such as a JeM flag, Akela Mujahid Jihad Kaisa Kare and digital files of Masood Azhar's speeches, which included instructions on bomb-making. Officials claim, from 2023 to February 2026, the group learned how to make Improvised Explosive Devices (IEDs), timer mechanisms and ways to set them off. They further allege the group tested at least eight homemade explosives in remote areas near their villages, trying out different pipe sizes, pressure levels, detonators, and casings.

Police claim to have found bomb-making manuals and PDFs about explosives on the phones of suspects. They also found messages with a suspected JeM handler in Pakistan through encrypted apps, suggesting outside links.

FROM PAGE - 1

Student protests gain national momentum

While Kolkata Police also received two emails seeking permission to hold a rally in the city under the banner of the CJP on Friday, SFI, the student wing of the CPI(M) held protests across Kerala, including a march to the Lok Bhavan in Thiruvananthapuram, in support of the CJP agitation in Delhi and the alleged police brutality there against students.

Meanwhile, senior BJP leader and former education minister, Murli Manohar Joshi came out in support of the protesting students. "It is painful to see young students from different parts of the country assembled for days on the streets of New Delhi. Their anxieties and concerns regarding the examination system are genuine and must be handled with empathy and a desire to find a lasting solution. I fervently hope that this is not treated merely as a law-and-order issue to be tackled through the use of force. It is very painful to see that even young girls were brutally mishandled," he posted on X.

On the other hand Opposition MPs and leaders of the INDIA alliance led by Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi led a march at Mahatma Gandhi memorial in Delhi's Tees January Marg on late Thursday evening following a strategy meeting on the crackdown on protesters. "MPs and leaders of the INDIA alliance are peacefully protesting at Gandhi Smriti on Tees January Marg. We are here to remember the students we lost - the children driven to take their own lives after the NEET paper leak. And we go to stand with the students who lie injured today - beaten for peacefully demanding justice and accountability. India's students are not alone. The entire Opposition stands with them and their demands," Rahul said.

Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray and Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS) president Raj Thackeray also announced a joint protest on Sunday to highlight the concerns of students and

their parents over the alleged police crackdown on protesters during CJP protest march and the NEET paper leak controversy.

Simultaneously Raj warned to "thrash" anyone who creates disorder during their "peaceful" protest in the offing. He said the march would start from Shivaji Park and conclude at the Siddhivinayak temple, stressing that participants would not carry any political party flags. Uddhav accused the Government of being insensitive, but said the student community was no longer intimidated.

CJP to meet Govt to break protest deadlock

Despite barricades, heightened security and suspending metro operations across 16 stations around Jantar Mantar protesters have been gathered at protest site.

"We are ready to discuss the issue on which the agitation has happened, and all the other related issues as well. Discussions can take place either at JP Nadda's office or residence. We do not stand on prestige. Union Health Minister JP Nadda and I will be present for discussions. Slowly, by way of discussion, we will progress towards a solution. This is a part of the series of continuous steps taken by the Government for the welfare of the students. Humbly, I appeal to you all to come and have discussions," Singh added.

The CJP, however, has insisted on talks either at the Jantar Mantar or at a neutral venue rejecting the proposal talks at JP Nadda's residence or office. Union minister Nadda reiterated Singh's remarks saying the Government is ready for further talks with the protesting youth, which can be held either at his office or residence.

"Please come forward so that we find a way out of this situation in the larger interest of the students' community, youth community and the nation at large. As you would also appreciate, this morning itself, Prime Minister Narendra Modi candidly spelt out that the interest of the students

is the foremost for this Government. The Government will go to any extent to safeguard the welfare of the students. Not only that, but the PM also took a very important decision to set up fast-track courts to deal with the cases related to those responsible for the recent paper leaks so that the final verdicts come early and decisively. Once again, I very humbly, on behalf of the Government, invite you to come forward," he said.

PM announces fast-track courts in paper leak...

According to him, PM Modi said State and Union Governments must join hands on the issue and that paper leaks is "not a matter of party politics but a matter of national interest".

Hitting back, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi blamed the PM for harming the future of youth reiterating the demand seeking Pradhan's resignation. "You are the one who has harmed the future of our youth the most. You allowed and encouraged the total capture and destruction of our education system — and protected every person responsible for it," Rahul posted on X in response to the PM's post.

Responding to the PM's first public remarks on the issue, CJP representative, Ashutosh Ranka alleged that paper leaks would continue unless accountability was fixed within the system. "The PM is talking about what punishment should be given after a paper leak occurs, but why is there no discussion on why paper leaks are happening in the first place?" Ranka said. "The announcement of fast-track courts is not a real solution. It is merely a distraction. The PM is making a cruel joke with the future of millions of students across this country. Paper leaks are not happening because India lacked fast-track courts. They are happening because Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan has been completely incompetent. He has failed to build a secure and foolproof examination system. Today, the youth of this country are demanding one thing above all else - accountability." Ranka said.

India and Israel cross new agricultural milestone

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

More than 3,500 farmers from across Haryana gathered in Munimpur village, Jhajjar district, on 17 June 2026 to inaugurate the 35th Indo-Israel Centre of Excellence (CoE) under the Indo-Israel Agricultural Project (IIAP). Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini, Agriculture Minister Shyam Singh Rana, and Israel's Ambassador to India, Reuven Azar, joined the event, underscoring the growing trust in this long-running bilateral partnership. The new centre, built at a cost of ₹8.50 crore, specialises in seed production technology, floriculture, and quality planting material. A companion Horticulture

Research Centre at Raiya, costing ₹13.27 crore, will focus on locally adapted horticultural crops and medicinal plants. Together, they mark another milestone in a programme that began with a single centre at Gharaunda in 2008 and has now expanded to 35 facilities across 12 states. Chief Minister Saini highlighted the centres' role in boosting farmer incomes through innovative technologies and international collaboration. Ambassador Azar pointed to a deeper shift: "The first Centre of Excellence, 30 years ago, was brought from Israel with Israeli components and technology. But this centre was built only by Indian companies with Indian components. Today and in the future, every



technology we bring from Israel will be produced in India and owned by India." This evolution from technology importer to domestic manufacturer reflects the programme's maturing model of practical knowledge transfer. Rather than abstract

research, the Centres operate as working demonstration farms showcasing protected cultivation, drip irrigation, fertigation, high-quality seedlings, and integrated pest management under Indian conditions. The scale is impressive. The network annually pro-

duces over 25 million quality vegetable seedlings and 387,000 fruit plants, while training around 1.2 lakh farmers each year. More than 250 Indian agricultural officers have received advanced training in Israel. The initiative has also grown into "Villages of Excellence" to spread modern practices across entire rural clusters. In a country where agriculture consumes the lion's share of freshwater and groundwater depletion is a pressing concern, the partnership's focus on resource efficiency is particularly valuable. Israeli expertise in water-scarce farming — pioneered through precision irrigation and protected cultivation — has been adapted to Indian realities,

helping farmers raise yields and quality while using fewer inputs. A new example is N-Drip, a gravity-powered micro-irrigation system introduced through Israel's MASHAV agency. By eliminating the need for pumps or electricity, it aims to bring precision irrigation within reach of small and marginal farmers. The true measure of success lies not just in numbers of centres or trainees, but in higher incomes, better produce, and more sustainable practices. As India balances the need to raise farm incomes with responsible resource use, the Indo-Israel model offers a proven template for long-term, practical technology transfer at scale.

Nation Focus



DRDO conducts maiden flight test of Kusha long-range missile

The DRDO on Thursday successfully conducted the maiden flight-test of Kusha long-range surface-to-air missile from the APJ Abdul Kalam Island off the coast of Odisha. The test was conducted against an "electronic target" simulating high-speed and high-altitude aerial threat which was successfully intercepted by the missile system, the defence ministry said. The Kusha missile system is capable of neutralising a wide variety of aerial threats including fighter jets, missiles, unmanned aerial vehicles and large enemy aircraft within a wide range and altitude envelope, the ministry said in a statement. (PTI)



Mizoram CM reviews key infrastructure projects

Mizoram Chief Minister Lalduhoma on Thursday chaired the fourth meeting of a high-level monitoring committee established in last year and reviewed the progress of major infrastructure projects across the state. The meeting of the Mizoram Pro-Active Governance and Timely Implementation (Mi-PRAGATI) focused on the ongoing construction of the Aizawl western side by-pass road, where issues related to the dumping site, pending compensation, refugee relocation and forest clearance were discussed, an official statement said. Officials presented reports on follow-up actions taken since previous meetings, and the chief minister instructed departments to pursue unresolved matters more vigorously. (PTI)

Houses of 2 LeT terrorists demolished, over 2,000 detained after cop killed in J&K

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

Sending out a stern message to the perpetrators behind the targeted killing of a police head constable deployed on Amamath yatra duty in the South Kashmir district of Anantnag, authorities on Thursday demolished the houses of two local Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) terrorists, believed to be active in the area. The action followed close on the heels of the detention of over 2000 suspected over-ground workers (OGWs) as part of an ongoing investigation into the Anantnag terror attack. In a related development, Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha also chaired a high-level security review meeting with senior officials from the Army, J&K Police, Civil Administration, central paramilitary forces, and key security agencies. Sinha directed officials to remain highly vigilant, step up intelligence-led anti-terror operations and proactively neutralise emerging security threats.

According to official sources, hours after the top brass of the Jammu and Kashmir Police paid floral tributes before dispatching the mortal remains of Head Constable Ashiq Hussain Qureshi to his native village in the central Kashmir district of Budgam for the last rites, the houses of local terrorists Adil Ahmad Thokar and Haroon Rashid Ganaie were razed to the ground during the intervening night of Wednesday and Thursday. The homes of Haroon Ganie and Adil Ahmad Thokar were demolished in the Hasanpora and Bijbehara areas of south Kashmir. Similar demolitions were carried out in the aftermath of the Pahalgam attack in April 2025, when the homes of at least nine suspected terrorists were blown up in different parts of the Valley. Later, a multi-storey house, belonging to Dr Umar Un Nabi, who allegedly triggered the car blast near the Red Fort Metro station on November

10, 2025, was demolished using explosives during the intervening night of November 13-14 in south Kashmir's Pulwama district. Meanwhile, Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah reacted strongly to these demolitions. He cautioned against wanton retributive action in the wake of a terror attack in Anantnag that killed a policeman on Wednesday, saying violence cannot be brought to an end without carrying the people along. "I understand the anger of the police, but the Supreme Court has issued an order stating that summary action of this kind should not be taken. "We witnessed a similar situation after the Pahalgam attack (in April 2025) when some people's houses were bulldozed. At that time, I had to speak to the Central Government to stop the trend," Abdullah told reporters. He also spoke out against the detention of hundreds of individuals in the Valley, stating that this "will not



People stand near debris after a house belonging to Haroon Rashid Ganaie, a Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) terrorist, was demolished at Bijbehara in Anantnag district, Jammu and Kashmir on Thursday

help improve the situation in J&K but in turn strain it further." The chief minister stated that while the police had blown up homes of suspected terrorists after the Pahalgam attack, the investigation showed that those involved in the attack were from outside J&K. Pointing to his previous stint as chief minister of the erstwhile state of Jammu and Kashmir, Abdullah said that based on his experience, the cycle of violence cannot be brought to an end without taking the people along.

"We can reach a certain point using the police, Army and the CRPF, but the real end will come only when the general public stands together against such violence. "After the Pahalgam incident, the general public expressed their anger and raised their voice against the terror attack. Even today, people are angry over how head constable Ashiq was brutally killed," Abdullah said. Referring to the detention of over-ground workers (OGWs) across the Kashmir Valley in the aftermath of

Wednesday's attack, the chief minister said when such reports come, people's anger turns against the system. "I hope we take our people along in this fight; only then will we achieve real success," Abdullah said. Former J&K chief minister and PDP chief Mehbooba Mufti said that demolishing houses of "alleged" terrorists was "collective punishment" that has no place in a democracy. "The killing of a police officer in the line of duty is a heinous and condemnable act. But detaining over a thousand people and demolishing the homes of families of two alleged militants amounts to collective punishment that has no place in a democracy," Mehbooba said in a post on X. If the Centre maintains that militancy has been reduced to near zero, it must adopt a more humane and lawful approach towards innocent civilians instead of resorting to "tit for tat" for an entire community, the former J&K chief minister said.

NIA arrests key absconder in PFI-linked Srinivasan murder case at IGI airport

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

On Thursday, the National Investigation Agency (NIA) arrested Muhammadali KP, a key absconder and former Palakkad district president of the banned Popular Front of India (PFI), at Indira Gandhi International Airport after he arrived from Riyadh, Saudi Arabia. This arrest is an important step in the 2022 Sreenivasan murder case and brings the total number of people in custody to 67. Muhammadali KP had been living in Saudi Arabia for four years. He was already one of the 65 people charged in the case registered as RC-02/2022/NIA/KOC.

The NIA has charged him under the Indian Penal Code and the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act. Authorities announced a reward of Rs three lakh for information leading to his arrest, and Interpol issued a Red Notice. Investigators say Muhammadali, from Palakkad district in Kerala, played a key role in planning the killing of Sreenivasan on April 16, 2022. According to the NIA, he helped organise the murder and gave shelter to those



involved. The agency took over the investigation in September 2022. It linked the crime to the PFI's larger goal of using violence to create communal divisions and what it calls a plan to establish Islamic rule in India by 2047. The NIA found that the PFI operated through a network of different wings and units. The group is accused of using its offices, campuses, and other facilities to train selected members in the use of weapons, while presenting these activities as physical education and yoga programs run by its PE Wing. "The Reporters Wing" gathered information about possible targets, and "Service Teams" carried out violent attacks. Investigators think Sreenivasan's murder was planned to create fear and divide communities. According to the NIA, the

accused worked together to promote violent extremism and jihad in India. With Muhammadali K.P. now in custody, the agency says its case against the other suspects is stronger, and it is still following leads about the group's wider network. The arrest at a major international airport highlights the NIA's ongoing efforts to find fugitives linked to banned groups. Officials said the accused had been living quietly in Saudi Arabia since leaving India after the case picked up speed. His return and arrest are important steps in the investigation and raise more questions about the PFI's methods and funding. The Sreenivasan murder case is still one of the most high-profile investigations since the PFI was banned. The NIA has already filed charge sheets against many of the accused and is still looking into the roles of different units within the group. The investigation is ongoing, with agencies focusing on the remaining networks and absconders. This latest development is expected to help the prosecution as the case moves through the courts, sources said.

India extends rare invitation to Bangladesh PM Tarique Rahman for BRICS Summit

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

In a notable diplomatic gesture, Prime Minister Narendra Modi has invited Bangladesh Prime Minister Tarique Rahman as a special guest to the 18th BRICS Summit, scheduled to be held on September 12-13 at Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi. Official sources confirmed that the invitation has already been conveyed to Dhaka. Bangladesh is neither a member nor an observer of BRICS, making the invitation significant. India currently holds the BRICS chairmanship for 2026, with the summit themed "Building Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainable Development."

According to Government sources, Tarique Rahman is likely to attend, which would mark his first visit to India since assuming office. This follows the February general elections in Bangladesh. Prime Minister Modi was among the first world leaders to invite the newly elected Bangladeshi leader. In April, Bangladesh Foreign Minister Dr Khalilur Rahman visited India, during which a possible prime ministerial visit was discussed. Relations between the two neighbours have remained lukewarm. Tarique Rahman had earlier chosen to visit China via Malaysia, signalling a departure from his predecessor Sheikh Hasina's approach of prioritising India.



Despite this, New Delhi has continued to extend cooperative gestures without expecting immediate reciprocity. If the visit materialises, Prime Minister Modi is expected to hold bilateral talks aimed at resetting ties and addressing issues of mutual interest for the benefit of both nations. The summit will see participation from BRICS members — now expanded to 11 countries — including

Chinese President Xi Jinping and Russian President Vladimir Putin. Leaders from Brazil, South Africa, Egypt, Ethiopia, Saudi Arabia, the UAE, and Indonesia are also expected. Iran's representation remains unclear. This invitation continues India's tradition of engaging Bangladesh at high-level multilateral platforms. Earlier, India had invited former Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina to the G20 Summit and Chief Adviser Muhammad Yunus to the Voice of the Global South Summit. Diplomatic observers view the move as an opportunity to open a new chapter in India-Bangladesh relations through sustained dialogue and cooperation.

Bestselling *Adam Nee Evide Aakunnu?* set to reach wider audience with english edition next month

SABLOO THOMAS
■ Thiruvananthapuram

After emerging as one of Kerala's biggest publishing successes in recent years, Chief Minister VD Satheesan's bestselling book *Adam Nee Evide Aakunnu?* (Adam, Where Are You?) is set to reach a national readership with the formal launch of its English translation next month. The Malayalam original, published by DC Books on May 9, 2026, has witnessed extraordinary commercial success, becoming a stand-out non-fiction bestseller in the state. Speaking to *The Pioneer*, DC Books publisher Ravi DC said more than 20,000 copies of the Malayalam edition were sold in just two months of its release, underscoring the remarkable demand the title has generated. "The translation has been carried out by Rauf Rumi. The English edition will be released before August 30, 2026, and will be available through major bookstores and digital platforms across India and overseas by mid-August," he added.



Spread across 200 pages, the book is a collection of 32 speeches delivered by Satheesan to Christian communities across Kerala. Rather than presenting a conventional political memoir, the work reflects on faith, governance, ethics and public life, examining how Biblical teachings have shaped the Chief Minister's personal values, political outlook and decades-long public career. Literary commentators have described the book as a reflective spiritual and philosophical journey that transcends partisan politics, portraying the introspective thoughts of a public leader

seeking deeper moral meaning. The volume also carries a foreword by noted academic Cyriac Thomas, adding scholarly weight to the reflections. With its combination of spiritual depth, political insight and ethical reflection, *Adam Nee Evide Aakunnu?* has already made a significant mark in Malayalam publishing. The forthcoming English edition is expected to extend that impact, positioning the book as one of the most notable literary contributions from Kerala to the wider Indian readership this year.

MPs in Parliamentary panel question officials over E20 fuel use

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Several MPs on Thursday questioned top Government officials over the rise in problems in vehicles due to the use of E20 (Ethanol-blended) fuel and asked what the Government was doing about it. Sources said the officials told the MPs during a department-related meeting of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Transport, Tourism and Culture that even though ethanol-blended fuel has been used for several years now, the problems in vehicles are a recent phenomenon. Asked what they were doing to check the problem, the officials said tests were underway to ascertain the reason behind



the rise in issues due to the use of E20 fuel. The sources added that the officials told the panel that the Government had already started ethanol-blended fuel to the extent of 19.2 per cent in 2022, which went up to 20 per cent only recently. Secretary in the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways, V Umashankar, and other stakeholders, including representatives from the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, oil marketing companies, SIAM, ARAI, ACMA and ICAT, were present at the meeting.



West Bengal civic heads lose power to issue birth certificates

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

The Bengal Government has decided to bar all civic heads including the panchayat pradhans, municipal chairmen and even the Mayors of various corporations from issuing birth certificates after massive irregularities in issuing the same across the State were found in recent inspections. The decision was on Thursday announced by State Chief Secretary Manoj Agarwal following reports suggesting about 25 per cent fake birth registrations from the samples checked. The rate of issuance of fake birth certificates witnessed a sudden rise between 2023 and February 2026 out of which there was a whopping rise in such cases in the last one year that incidentally coincided with special intensive revision of electoral rolls ahead of the recently concluded Assembly elections. The Bengal police administration has also started conducting simultaneous raids at various places including municipalities, Corporations, panchayats and even the burning ghats to find out fake registration of deaths apparently in order to establish backward linkages of persons whose parents were not registered as voters in 2002 electoral rolls. According to Government sources in one district about 11 thousand certificates were found to be fake out of a sample of 47,000. Most number of fake certificates were found in Malda, Murshidabad, two Dinajpurs, two 24 Parganas, Nadia and Birbhum, sources said. For

instance the figure was 16000 in Malda compared to 8,000 in Murshidabad. While North Dinajpur recorded a massive 58,000 issuances there were about 19,000 fake certificates to be found in North 24 Parganas. Police raids were conducted in various wards and central record room in the Kolkata Municipal Corporation, sources said adding the police also raided the registry at burning ghats in Kolkata. The Government had received many such complaints, Agarwal said adding such irregularities were noticed during SIR. "Many people have taken advantage of the situation" bypassing the rules... If anyone has knowingly and deliberately committed fraud, they won't be spared." However the top official iterated that the "initiative is being undertaken to restore transparency. It will not cause problems for anyone. Those who have obtained genuine birth certificates have no cause for worry or fear." Keeping the largescale malpractices in issuance of birth certificates the Government has also decided to seize the power of issuing such certificates from the panchayat pradhans, municipal chairmen and even Corporation Mayors. "The officers will issue birth certificates," the officer said. In order to prevent fraud, the Government would fully integrate its systems with the central Civil Registration System (CRS) portal, he said adding the Government would proceed with a humane approach and that no one required to be scared.

■ States Focus ■



SC HAS 96,000 PENDING CASES: LAW MINISTER TELLS RS

The Supreme Court has more than 96,000 pending cases, with over 10,000 awaiting disposal for more than a decade, the Rajya Sabha was told on Thursday. Collectively, 5.64 crore cases are pending across courts, including the top court, the 25 high courts and district and subordinate courts.

Citing data available on the National Judicial Data Grid, Law Minister Arjun Meghwal said in a written reply that as many as 80,660 cases are pending for more than 30 years across high courts.

In the top court, while 26 cases are pending for more than 30 years, 558 are awaiting disposal for over 20 years, he said. The disposal of cases, the minister said, is within the exclusive domain of the judiciary.

Pendency of cases in courts arises due to several factors, including complexity of facts involved, nature of evidence, and cooperation of stakeholders " Bar, investigating agencies, witnesses and litigants. (PTI)



YSRCP TO HOLD STATEWIDE YOUTH RALLIES ON JULY 28

The YSRCP on Thursday announced statewide protest rallies by its youth and student wings in all district headquarters on July 28, alleging that the Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu Government had betrayed students and unemployed youth.

The opposition party alleged that the Government had promised to provide unemployment allowance until jobs were given but had accumulated dues running into thousands of crores.

"The Government has failed to honour its promises to the youth and ignored serious irregularities in the Mega District Selection Committee (DSC) recruitment process. We demand a CBI probe on this," a YSRCP press release said. (PTI)

Jammu flash flood death toll rises to 26

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

The death toll in the recent rain-triggered flash floods and landslides across Jammu region rose to 26 on Thursday with the recovery of the body of a 25-year-old woman from Poonch district, officials said.

The body of Khalida Kouser, wife of Yasar Iqbal of Murrah village, was recovered near the Fazalabad foot-bridge in Surankote during a search operation.

She had been washed away in the devastating flash floods that struck the area on the night of July 18, they said.

Officials said the decomposed body was shifted to the Sub-district hospital in Surankote, where the village lambardar, Zakir Hussain, identified it.

After completing legal formalities, they said the body was handed over to her family for the last rites.



A damaged footbridge over the Lidder River following flash floods triggered by heavy rainfall in Pahalgam, Anantnag district, Jammu and Kashmir PTI

With the latest recovery, the death toll in Poonch district has risen to 17, the highest among the affected districts and a total of 26 in the Jammu region, they said.

Overall, 29 people have lost their lives in the rain-related incidents across Jammu and Kashmir, including two deaths in Bandipora district and one in Budgam district in the Kashmir valley.

Those, who died in the flash floods in Murrah hamlet

on the night of July 18 include 59 year Noor Safia wife of Mohd Latief, 16 year old son Sajad Ahmed son, Haqnawaz Ahmed (11), Shah Nawaz Ahmed (11), daughter Khaldi Kouser wife of Yasar Iqbal (25) and grand child 2 year old Sofian, and other kins Bano Bi wife of Mohd Hussain (60) and Mohd Akram son of Mohd Liaqat (7).

Officials said search operations are continuing as six people are still missing.

Assam CM visits flood-hit Golaghat, reviews relief operations

TONY DAS ■ Golaghat/Dispur

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Wednesday visited flood-affected areas of Golaghat district to assess the damage caused by the recent floods and review ongoing rescue, relief and rehabilitation efforts. During the visit, he also interacted with displaced residents at relief camps and assured them of continued Government support.

The Chief Minister first visited the relief camp at Bhaskar Senior Basic School in Kamarbandha, where 178 flood-affected people are currently taking shelter.

He spoke with camp inmates to understand their concerns, daily needs and the challenges they are facing.

Following the visit, Sarma said the district administra-



tion and concerned departments had been instructed to ensure that all essential services and relief materials reach affected families on priority. According to official figures, the recent floods have impacted 25,791 people in Golaghat district.

He later visited another relief camp at Numaligarh Higher Secondary School, which is sheltering 182 dis-

placed people, including a large number of children. The Chief Minister interacted with the children and enquired about their well-being.

Addressing reporters after the visits, Sarma said the floods had caused extensive damage to agricultural land and livestock, while disrupting the lives of thousands of families across the district. He

1,200 rescued from Gujarat's rain-hit areas, 1 dead in Tapi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

Around 1,200 people have been rescued and hundreds more relocated to safer places as heavy showers battered south Gujarat districts, where Umbergaon taluka received over 1,100 mm rains in just 16 hours, an official said Thursday. One rain-related death was reported in Tapi district, while teams from the National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) and the state's SDRF as well as the Indian Air Force (IAF) and Coast Guard were put on alert for rescue efforts, he said. Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel reviewed the rain situation and also spoke to Union Home Minister Amit Shah, who assured the Gujarat Government of all necessary assistance.

Valsad district was the worst affected by the recent rains with Umbergaon taluka receiving over 1,100 mm rains between 6 am on Wednesday and 10 am on Thursday, State



A vehicle partially submerged in a waterlogged underpass after heavy rainfall, near Sabarmati riverfront in Ahmedabad on Thursday PTI

Emergency Operation Centre (SEOC) data showed. Many other talukas in the district received over 600 mm rains during the same period, it said.

A 'red alert', warning of heavy to extremely heavy rainfall, was in effect since Wednesday for the southern districts of Valsad, Navsari, Surat, and Tapi, with NDRF and SDRF teams deployed there for rescue operations. Relief Commissioner Gaurang Makwana said.

"The Air Force and Coast Guard are also on alert and people will be airlifted if necessary, once weather condi-

tions improve," he told reporters. Makwana informed that deployment of disaster management personnel is being scaled up in view of increase in the intensity of rainfall, and rescue operations are being conducted in coordination with the administration, police, and local volunteers. "1,200 people have been rescued, and 1,500 residents in Surat moved to safe locations. In Navsari district, 200 people stranded across 11 villages due to rise in the water level of the Kaveri river have been rescued and relocated to safety," said the IAS officer.

Severe flooding in Maharashtra's Palghar district; 891 rescued



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Palghar

A massive relief and rescue operation was launched in Maharashtra's coastal Palghar district on Thursday after heavy rains cut off several villages in Dahanu and Talasari talukas, inundating low-lying areas and leading to power outages.

Emergency response teams have so far rescued 891 people or 218 families from flood-affected areas while some two lakh people are living without electricity, officials said. Collector Dr Indu Rani Jakhar said the district has been receiving torrential rainfall since Wednesday night, with Dahanu and Talasari bearing the brunt.

All educational institutions in the district have been ordered to remain closed on Thursday, she said. "National Disaster Response Force (NDRF) teams have been deployed in Talasari and Dahanu to carry out rescue operations," she said, adding that an emergency rescue team from the Vasai-Virar Municipal Corporation

(VVMC) and a local rescue unit at Bharad (Charoti) have also been helping stranded residents. A person was found dead in a nullah in the district, Collector Jakhar said. The identity of the deceased was yet to be established.

Water is being discharged from Kurje and Dhamani dams as they are filled to capacity. "All villages situated along the canal banks have been put on high alert, and the local administration is maintaining continuous vigil," the Collector stated, urging people to refrain from non-essential travel and stay away from submerged roads, bridges, and overflowing water bodies.

The flooding has also caused severe damage to the power infrastructure, leaving around two lakh people without electricity.

Ajit Igatpurikar, Deputy Chief PRO (Kalyan Region) for Maharashtra State Electricity Distribution Company Ltd, stated in a release that floodwaters inundated 17 electrical substations, forcing authorities to shut down 106 feeders as a safety precaution.

UAE eyes energy, food, semiconductor sectors for stronger investment ties with Gujarat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

The United Arab Emirates (UAE) on Thursday said it is looking at expanding investments in Gujarat in sectors such as food security, energy, logistics and semiconductors as the Gulf country seeks to deepen economic ties with India.

UAE Minister of Economy and Tourism Abdulla Bin Touq Al Marri noted the growing strategic partnership between India and his country has created opportunities for greater business-to-business collaboration across key sectors.

Al Marri, who was in Ahmedabad to participate in the India edition of 'Investopia Global', identified energy as another major area of cooperation between the two sides as countries worldwide transition towards cleaner sources of power.

Speaking to media after the inaugural event, the visiting minister said food security remains a priority area as the UAE imports more than 90 per cent of its edible requirements, with a significant share of processed food, fruits and vegetables coming from India. Asked which sectors hold the greatest potential for



increased UAE investments in Gujarat, Al Marri identified food security, energy, logistics and semiconductors as key focus areas.

"A large portion of our processed food, vegetables and fruits comes from India.

That itself shows the huge growth potential between both countries," he maintained. Al Marri said energy would remain another major area of cooperation as countries move towards cleaner sources of power.

"Energy is the next fuel for the world. We are moving from hydrogen to renewables, especially to support data centres, which require massive amounts of energy," he emphasised.

Referring to logistics and supply chains, he said the UAE has maintained a long-term presence in India's port infrastructure. "DP World (a multinational logistics firm based in Dubai) has invested in Mundra Port (in Gujarat) and we continue to see logistics and connectivity as an important area of cooperation," he said.

On whether new invest-

ment avenues could emerge from his Gujarat visit, Al Marri insisted the objective of Investopia was to facilitate business-to-business engagement rather than announce projects immediately.

At the inaugural event, Gujarat Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel invited UAE businesses to invest in the state, saying the Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) between India and the UAE has strengthened bilateral economic ties and opened new opportunities for trade and investment.

BRICS health ministers adopt 16th health declaration

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

The 16th BRICS Health Ministers' Meeting was held here on Thursday under India's BRICS Chairship 2026, with major outcome being the unanimous adoption of the Health Ministerial Declaration, reflecting the shared commitment of BRICS countries to deepen health cooperation and strengthen resilient, equitable and people-centric health systems.

The Ministers' meeting concluded successfully bringing



together Health Ministers, Heads of Delegation, senior officials and public health experts from BRICS member

countries to strengthen cooperation in addressing shared public health priorities and advancing a resilient global

health architecture.

Convened under India's BRICS Chairship theme, "Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability," the Meeting provided a platform for member countries to deliberate on key health challenges and reaffirm their collective commitment towards strengthening health systems, promoting innovation, enhancing pandemic preparedness and advancing Universal Health Coverage through sustained cooperation.

Raja Raghuvanshi kin welcome SC order on Sonam bail

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Indore

The kin of murdered Indore businessman Raja Raghuvanshi welcomed the Supreme Court's decision on Thursday to set aside the bail of his wife and main accused in the case, Sonam Raghuvanshi, and asserted it had renewed their hope of getting justice.

The apex court allowed a plea filed by the Meghalaya Government challenging the bail granted to Sonam. A bench of justices M M



Sundresh and PB Varale granted her three weeks to surrender before police.

"We have finally got a little happiness after a long time. My son has been dead

for more than a year. I still cry whenever I look at his photograph. Sonam deserves the death penalty," Raja's father Ashok Raghuvanshi told PTI.

Only parents know the effort and years of sacrifice involved in bringing up a child, he said while trying to hold back his tears. "The Supreme Court's latest order has given us fresh hope that we will ultimately get justice," he added.

He said Sonam's family had not contacted them since Raja's murder, adding

that his family no longer wished to have any communication with them.

Raja's mother Uma Raghuvanshi said she felt relieved because a woman like Sonam should not have been out of jail.

"Our family was worried about its safety after Sonam was released on bail. My innocent son was brutally murdered. I am confident a mother's hope will not be shattered and Sonam will receive the strictest punishment from the court," she said.

Around 26,000 flights cancelled due to West Asia airspace curbs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Indian airlines have cancelled around 26,000 international flights till July 20 besides flight diversions and delays due to airspace restrictions in the wake of the US-Iran conflict, according to the Government.

Minister of State for Civil Aviation Murlidhar Mohol on Thursday told the Lok Sabha that airlines are incurring significant revenue losses due to the ongoing crisis and are taking measures to miti-



gate the impact while ensuring continuity of operations. The conflict, which started

in late February, has significantly impacted the airline industry, which is grappling with high fuel costs and airspace curbs in the West Asia region.

"The US-Iran conflict has significantly disrupted international flight operations due to airspace restrictions leading to widespread cancellations (approx 26,000 flights by Indian carriers till 20 July 2026), along with considerable diversions and delays across airlines and airports," Mohol said in a written reply.

Shiv Sena UBT to hold Tiranga Morcha in Mumbai on July 24

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Aaditya Thackeray on Thursday said his party will organise a 'Tiranga morcha' on July 24 in solidarity with the students demanding resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over exam irregularities.

The party earlier said the 'Tiranga morcha' will be held at Shivaji Park in Dadar on July 24.

However, on Thursday, Aaditya, along with Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS) leader Amit



Thackeray said, the march was postponed as many who wanted to participate said the event should be deferred to weekend and a decision

was taken accordingly.

However, hours later, Aaditya, speaking to reporters, said he received overwhelming response in

the form of messages and calls for the demonstration.

People wanted to articulate their views on issues related to students and express their sentiments so the Tiranga morcha will be held on Friday (July 24) at 5pm, said the Opposition MLA.

The protest march will be organised without any political flag, he said and urged people to join the agitation in large numbers.

Earlier in the day, Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray and MNS president Raj Thackeray announced a separate

morcha on July 26 to convey the "angst" of students and their parents for the alleged police atrocities against agitators and the NEET paper leak, which has triggered widespread protests.

Raj Thackeray said the morcha will begin from Shivaji Park in Dadar and culminate at the Siddhivinayak Temple in the Prabhdevi area. He insisted no political flags will be displayed during the protest, he said.

Mumbai has been witnessing protests since Monday in solidarity with the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP)-led students' agitation in New Delhi.

Chaos in Bihar Assembly over student protests, police action in Patna

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

Both Houses of the Bihar legislature on Thursday witnessed turmoil as members of the ruling NDA and the Opposition traded charges over the violent students' protest in the State Capital a day earlier.

Proceedings in the Assembly, which began at 11 am, were adjourned by Speaker Prem Kumar till lunch within minutes when several members of the ruling side rose in their seats, blaming the Opposition for the day-long pitched battle between the police and the protesters.

Many of the NDA legislators had trooped into the Well and some of them, including Sanjeev Chaurasia and Vinay Bihari of the BJP and JD(U)'s Manjeet Singh, were seen heading menacingly towards the Opposition MLAs.

The NDA legislators were heard alleging that "goons, not students" were taking part in the "so-called protests" on Wednesday when at least 22 police personnel sustained injuries in a day-long pitched battle, which had ended in a final showdown close to the Chief Minister's residence.

Emerging from the House after it was adjourned, Opposition MLAs led by Alok



Mehta of the RJD told reporters, "The BJP and its allies have not learnt their lessons despite seeing so much public anger. They alleged that protesters were goons, though their own conduct today befitted ruffians. We had to run for our lives." However, BJP leader and minister Ram Kripal Yadav maintained, "The Congress-led opposition is trying to plunge the country into anarchy. The diabolical plan was on display in Patna yesterday when anti-social elements, posing as students, clashed with police, roughed up journalists and even manhandled a couple of our fellow MLAs. The government will identify the miscreants and take them to task."

Notably, at least two BJP MLAs, Vinay Bihari and Rohit Pandey, were also attacked by the protesters who

spotted them heading for the Assembly to attend the monsoon session, which comes to a close on Friday. Vehicles of the legislators were also damaged by the rampaging mob, and videos of the two MLAs running to safety have gone viral.

In apprehension of further nuisance, gates of the Vidhan Sabha premises were sealed, and legislators, journalists and staff members remained locked inside well after the day's proceedings had come to an end. Yadav also claimed to have learnt that "a female constable was stabbed with a dagger by one of the criminals who prowled the streets pretending to be student activists".

"It was all part of a huge conspiracy that was aimed at bringing a bad name to our Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary and, eventually,

destabilise the Government of Prime Minister Narendra Modi", alleged Yadav.

When Patna Senior Superintendent of Police Kartikeya K Sharma was asked about the reported stabbing of a female constable, he replied, "We are looking into it. Action will be taken upon investigation".

However, CPI(ML) Liberation MLA Sandeep Saurav, who had led the protest, debunked the charge and said, "It is high time that the BJP and its allies realised that the country's youth is outraged over the brutal repression of Jantar Mantar protests in Delhi where policemen had the temerity to poke sticks into the bodies of girls who were demanding action over NEET exam paper leaks".

"It is laughable that the NDA, which rules the Centre as well as the State, and has made all the institutions dance to its tunes, is pointing fingers at the opposition. They run the risk of facing greater public fury unless they stop quarrelling with us and get down to solving the problems that have brought our youth out on the streets," he said.

Meanwhile, uproarious scenes were also seen inside the legislative council after an adjournment motion moved by RJD's Abdul Bari

Siddiqui was rejected by Chairman Awadhesh Narayan Singh.

Soon, a number of the opposition MLCs rushed into the Well, prompting the chairman to adjourn the proceedings till 2.30 pm.

Later, senior JD(U) leader and minister Ashok Choudhary told reporters, "The Government will take action against those involved in unlawful activities yesterday. Of course, they have been instigated by the Opposition parties. We have learnt that BJP workers were attacked by their counterparts in the Congress with sticks fitted with nails".

Choudhary was referring to the clash that had erupted at Sadaqat Ashram, the state Congress headquarters, where several BJP workers, led by State president Sanjay Saraogi, were demonstrating to register their protest against the gherao of PM Modi's residence by Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi, among others.

However, Siddiqui, whose party is a Congress ally, said, "The ruling dispensation is shutting its eyes to the fact that the atmosphere today is very much like in 1974, when the youth had rallied behind Jayaprakash Narayan and the mass uprising set the tone for the overthrow of the Government a few years later."

Sikkim tunnel collapse: Rescue teams retrieve bodies of all 25 workers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Namchi

The bodies of all 25 workers have been retrieved from an under-construction NHPC hydropower project tunnel that had collapsed in Sikkim's Namchi district, officials said on Thursday.

The labourers were inside the NHPC Teesta Stage VI Hydropower Project tunnel under construction, which collapsed following an explosion suspected to have been caused by methane gas shortly after 1 pm on Monday.

All the bodies have now been recovered after 72 hours of continuous search operations, KK Roy, a member of the rescue team from Eastern Coalfield Ltd, told reporters.

"The Sikkim Government, district administration, and all concerned agencies continue to closely monitor the situation, while extending every possible support to the affected families," a state government official said.



Eight bodies had been identified till Wednesday. Of them, four are from Jalpaiguri district of West Bengal while one each from Punjab, Uttarakhand, Assam and Sikkim.

At least four workers from Jharkhand's Khunti, Hazaribag and West Singhbhum districts were engaged there, another official said.

The NHPC on Wednesday announced an ex gratia of ₹5 lakh for the next of kin of each person who died in the accident.

Sikkim Chief Minister Prem

Singh Tamang on Tuesday announced ₹4 lakh ex gratia for the next of kin of each of those workers who died in the accident, and ₹50,000 for every injured person.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi also announced an ex gratia of ₹2 lakh for each of the next of kin of the deceased, and ₹50,000 each to the injured persons.

According to an NHPC statement, a sudden burst of suspected methane gas trapped/embedded inside the rocks led to the explosion, generating dense fumes and toxic gases in the tunnel.

GMC Bhopal develops AI-based oral cancer screening device

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhopal

In a major breakthrough aimed at strengthening early detection of oral cancer, Gandhi Medical College (GMC), Bhopal has developed an Artificial Intelligence (AI)-based oral cancer screening device along with a mobile application capable of identifying the disease at an early stage. The screening device has also received a design patent from the Government of India, marking a significant milestone in the use of indigenous technology for public healthcare.

Developed by the Department of Dental Surgery, the innovation combines an AI-enabled screening device with the 'Mukh Aarogya App', which analyses photographs of the oral cavity to detect suspicious lesions and early signs of oral cancer within minutes. The technology is expected to improve community-level screening and facilitate timely diagnosis, particularly in rural and underserved areas where access to specialists is limited.

The application has been designed to support frontline healthcare workers, including Accredited Social Health Activists (ASHAs), Community Health Officers (CHOs) and staff posted at Primary Health Centres. Using a smartphone, healthcare workers can capture images of a patient's oral cavity, which are then analysed by the AI system. Individuals identified with suspected cancer can be promptly referred to specialist hospitals for further investigation and treatment, helping reduce delays that often result in advanced-stage diagnosis.



Professor and Head of the Department of Dental Surgery Anuj Bhargav said early detection remains the most effective strategy for reducing mortality from oral cancer. Detecting the disease at an initial stage not only improves treatment outcomes but also reduces the complexity and cost of treatment while significantly increasing the chances of complete recovery. He said the project has been developed to empower frontline healthcare workers with AI-driven diagnostic support and establish an efficient referral mechanism for suspected patients.

India reports nearly 1.5 lakh new cases of oral cancer every year, making it one of the country's most serious public health concerns. Madhya Pradesh continues to record a high burden of the disease, with the incidence among men estimated at around 25 cases per lakh population. Bhopal is also considered one of the cities with a relatively high prevalence of oral cancer.

The research and development project was carried out under the guidance of Dean Kavita Ain Singh, with significant contributions from Richa Sharma and Animesh Barodiya of the Department of Dental Surgery.

ANNA HAZARE UNDERTAKES SILENT PROTEST TO SUPPORT STUDENTS

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahilyanagar

Social activist Anna Hazare on Thursday observed a two-hour-long *maun andolan* (silent protest) at Ahilyanagar in Maharashtra to extend his support for protesting students in Delhi.

Anna began his protest at 11 am at the Mahatma Gandhi statue in Ahilyanagar and ended it at 1 pm, before leaving for his village Ralegan Siddhi, located in the same district.

Hazare wrote to Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday saying "the news of violence and police action is extremely painful".



In a letter to Modi, Hazare said the resentment of the protesters must be viewed "not as a law and order problem, but as the agony and expectations of society". If Union Education Minister is asked to resign, "it will not cause the Government to fall; rather, it will make its functioning more accountable and effective", Hazare wrote.

He requested the Government to "listen to (the protesters) patiently, create an atmosphere of trust, and find solutions through positive dialogue". Hazare told reporters that he wrote to Modi as the prime minister is "the supreme leader and should be apprised of people's issues".

Razing houses won't improve things, says Omar Abdullah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Srinagar

Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah on Thursday cautioned against wanton retributive action in the wake of a terror attack in Anantnag that killed a policeman on Wednesday, saying violence cannot be brought to an end without carrying the people along.

"I understand the anger of the police, but the Supreme Court has issued an order stating that summary action of this kind should not be taken. "We witnessed a similar situation after the Pahalgam attack (in April 2025) when some people's houses were bulldozed. At that time, I had to speak to the Central government to stop the trend," Abdullah told reporters here.

The remarks followed after the authorities demolished the houses of two Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) terrorists in Anantnag, hours after head constable Ashiq Hussain was shot dead in south Kashmir.

The houses of Adil Thokar and Haroon Rashid Ganaie, both active terrorists, were razed to the ground on the intervening night of Wednesday-Thursday, officials said. Constable Ashiq Hussain, who was on Amarnath Yatra security duty, was shot dead



by a lone terrorist at the Lal Chowk in Anantnag on Wednesday afternoon.

Abdullah said that during the investigation into last year's Pahalgam terror attack, "it turned out that not a single local was involved and all the attackers had come from outside". "Demolishing houses or making thousands of arrests will not improve the situation; in fact, it will only worsen it," he said. Pointing to his previous stint as chief minister of the erstwhile state of Jammu and Kashmir, Abdullah said that based on his experience, the cycle of violence cannot be brought to an end without taking the people along.

"We can reach a certain point using the police, Army and the CRPF, but the real end will come only when the general public stands together against such violence.

Suwendu seeks death penalty for gateman in Murshidabad accident

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Baharampur

West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Thursday directed the police to expedite the investigation into the Murshidabad level crossing accident that claimed five lives and said the prosecution should seek capital punishment for the arrested gateman. Adhikari gave directions after meeting the victims' families and handing over cheques of ₹5 lakh each.

A train rammed into a school vehicle, killing five people, including four students, at the Govindpur level crossing on July 17.

"I am directing the police clearly to complete their investigation while the accused gateman is still in custody. They must submit the chargesheet while he is still in custody. A custodial trial must be conducted so that he is awarded capital punishment," he said.

Adhikari instructed the SP and DM of Murshidabad to monitor the investigation closely, stating that a special public prosecutor will be appointed.

He also asked local MLA Bharat Kumar Jhawar to



keep track of the case and regularly update him.

The Chief minister flew to Baharampur by helicopter around noon and travelled by road to Govindpur, stopping briefly at the accident site before meeting the bereaved families at a programme held in the Govindpur village. State minister Gaurishankar Ghosh, DM Rajarshi Mitra, SP Sachin Makkar, Belidanga MLA Jhawar and other senior officials were present. Adhikari met the families individually before the programme and appeared emotional during the interactions.

"I have spoken to the families of the deceased separately. I am with them. Let the almighty give them strength so that they can overcome this tragedy," he said. The CM said he had assigned specific responsi-

bilities to the district administration to address some of the demands raised by the families and assured them that several issues would be resolved within the next 15 days.

"I will also ask the villagers to stand by these families so that they do not feel alone or suffer from depression. Like the police administration, I will also keep a tab on their social support. MLA Jhawar and minister Ghosh will also monitor the situation," he said. Referring to those injured in the accident, Adhikari said doctors at Murshidabad Medical College and Hospital had made every effort to save the victims. "We tried a lot to save everybody, but could not. Two people are still undergoing treatment," he said.

Indian national arrested in California over drug trafficking

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

Early Tuesday in California's Central Valley, California Highway Patrol officers arrested Harmanveer Singh, 31, an Indian national from Punjab who also used the names Hari Gautam and Harman Sandhu. Singh is now in federal custody. While his arrest was discreet, the network he allegedly served was not.

The FBI had been watching Singh for less than a month. On June 23, a federal warrant from Los Angeles charged him with conspiracy to distribute and possess controlled substances, conspiracy to export them, and possession with intent to distribute. By July 21 or 22, he was in custody. The quick arrest shows the ongoing pressure on the network he belonged to.

Prosecutors say Singh was part of the Ravinder Dhandha Organised Crime Group, based in Vancouver, which often moved drugs across the US-Canada border. The group is accused of transporting large amounts of cocaine and methamphetamine for trafficking groups in the United States, Canada, and Mexico. Every week, hundreds of kilograms left the Los Angeles area including West Covina, Ontario, Fontana, and Perris-hidden in long-haul trucks and farm vehicles. The indictment says at least 430 kilo-



grams of cocaine travelled this route between summer 2023 and November 2024.

Ravinder Singh Dhandha, 57, also known as "John Wick," is named as the group's leader. He and his associate, Jaskarn Baghri from Surrey, are accused of handling storage, transportation, and distribution. Authorities in British Columbia have started seizing two of Dhandha's properties, worth over \$6 million, saying they are proceeds of crime. Singh's role is less well known, but the FBI's choice to issue a wanted poster suggests he played a significant part.

Singh was arrested as part of a larger operation involving several agencies. In early July, the FBI, RCMP, and European partners started Operation Hard Ball to target three India-linked transnational criminal groups tied to Lawrence Bishnoi, Jaggu Bhagwanpuria, and Ravinder Dhandha.

Authorities charged thirty-seven people and arrested twenty-four across three continents, including eleven in California. At first, Singh managed to avoid arrest and was listed publicly by the FBI. Still, the California Highway Patrol eventually caught him in Stockton, a city known for cross-border trafficking.

PROSECUTORS SAY SINGH WAS PART OF THE RAVINDERDHANDA ORGANISED CRIME GROUP, BASED IN VANCOUVER, WHICH OFTEN MOVED DRUGS ACROSS THE US-CANADA BORDER

These networks are more than just isolated gangs. They work as logistics experts, offering smuggling services to other groups while expanding their own operations. According to one informant, Dhandha mentioned plans to start a new "cartel" during a meeting in South Surrey in January 2025. The group's large ambitions are clear from the scale of their activities, their professional methods of hiding their work, and their ability to keep operating even as international attention grows.

Singh's arrest in a California trucking town draws attention to a trafficking route that has mostly gone unnoticed. This route connects operators from Punjab, safe locations in Canada, supply routes in California, and demand in Mexico, all through the same network.

The investigation will continue until those in charge of logistics are found and arrested. Upcoming federal court hearings in Los Angeles will show how involved Singh was.

Need to focus more on food processing sector: Union minister Chirag Paswan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Minister Chirag Paswan on Thursday stressed on the need to focus more on the food processing sector as it has the potential to enhance farmers' income, create jobs and reduce wastage of agriculture as well as horticulture crops.

Addressing an event organised by Indian Chamber of Commerce (ICC), the Food Processing Industries Minister highlighted that the government in the last 12 years has taken various measures for the growth of this sector, including 100 per cent foreign direct investment (FDI).

However, he said, "we have a long way to go" as he promised to continue reform process for ease of doing business. Paswan said there is a need to focus more on the food processing sector, as it can address multiple challenges such as increasing farmers' income, reducing food wastage and creation of employment opportunities.

He asked food companies to expand their business to



tap the immense potential in this sector but warned them of making any compromise on quality.

The minister said the processing units need to be established close to the farmers' agriculture field.

Paswan reiterated on the need to strongly counter the false narrative on social media that all processed food products are bad.

"For us, processed food means value creation," Paswan asserted.

On Wednesday, the minister had said the government is targeting to double food processing level to 25 per cent in next five years.

At the event, Rajeev Singh,

Director General of the ICC, underlined the role of trade and technology in reshaping the farm sector.

"Two thirds of our population still depends on agriculture, and the gaps we speak of most often are at the farm level and in the movement of produce from farm to market. What is transforming this space today is technology and access to information," he said.

With nine free trade agreements now in place with more than 32 countries, Singh said India's agriculture exports are set for a real shift, and that will benefit growers and the wider economy.



Editor's
TAKE

The US ends its clear non-proliferation policy

By diluting non-proliferation checks while signing a deal with Saudi Arabia, the US may have opened the door to nuclear competition in the Gulf

On July 22, US Energy Secretary Chris Wright and Saudi Energy Minister Prince Abdulaziz bin Salman signed a Section 123 agreement and an accompanying safeguards pact, formalising the framework agreed during Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman's November 2025 White House visit. The 30-year deal gives American firms, led by Westinghouse, the lead role in building Saudi Arabia's civilian nuclear sector and commits both sides to a two-year study on whether domestic enrichment is commercially viable. Any resulting facility would reportedly be built by US companies under a tightly guarded "black box" arrangement meant to withhold sensitive technology from Saudi hands. Congress now has 90 days to review the agreement.

What alarms non-proliferation specialists is what the deal omits. Unlike the UAE's 2009 "gold standard" pact, which barred enrichment and reprocessing outright, the Saudi agreement contains no such prohibition and skips the IAEA's Additional Protocol, granting inspectors wider access. Riyadh has pointedly declined to renounce enrichment. Analysts at the Arms Control Association and the Carnegie Endowment warn it could become the precedent Turkey, Egypt or even the UAE cite to seek similar terms.

The unease is sharpened by Crown Prince Mohammed's own past pledge to match any Iranian bomb and by Saudi Arabia's new mutual-defence pact with nuclear-armed Pakistan, widely read as an informal deterrent umbrella. Notably, Secretary of State Marco Rubio spent his Senate years insisting on exactly the guardrails this deal now lacks. The timing compounds the risk.

The agreement was finalised as US and Israeli strikes continued against Iranian nuclear sites, meant to stop Tehran from weaponising its programme. Democratic Representative Brad Sherman put the contradiction bluntly: a government fighting a war over proliferation should not facilitate it elsewhere for commercial gain. Senator Ed Markey warned the deal risks igniting a regional arms race rather than restraining one.

For Washington, the logic is largely commercial and strategic: tens of billions of dollars for a resurgent US nuclear industry, American jobs and a foothold that locks Riyadh into US technology and fuel supply chains ahead of Chinese, Russian and French competitors.

It also anchors a broader reset with Saudi Arabia spanning F-35 sales and AI cooperation, as Trump consolidates Gulf partnerships and Riyadh pursues energy diversification under Vision 2030. Regionally, the deal marks a genuine pivot. Nuclear cooperation was long held out as the reward for Saudi normalisation with Israel; delivering it without that condition has infuriated Israeli officials, who see their unique regional nuclear status eroding just as normalisation drifts further out of reach. Whether Congress lets the deal stand will shape Gulf security – and the credibility of US non-proliferation policy – for years to come.

AI can reshape environmental governance

As India confronts growing challenges of water stress, climate change and rapid urbanisation, AI can become a powerful instrument for integrating environmental data, anticipating risks and strengthening governance itself



LEENA NANDAN



SURYAPRABHA SADASIVAN

Artificial intelligence is rapidly becoming central to India's development story. Through the IndiaAI Mission and investments in digital infrastructure, data centres and advanced computing, India has made clear its ambition to become a global AI leader.

Increasingly, the national conversation has moved beyond AI models and computing power to how AI can strengthen institutions, improve productivity and address real-world development challenges. Yet one important area has received relatively little attention: environmental governance.

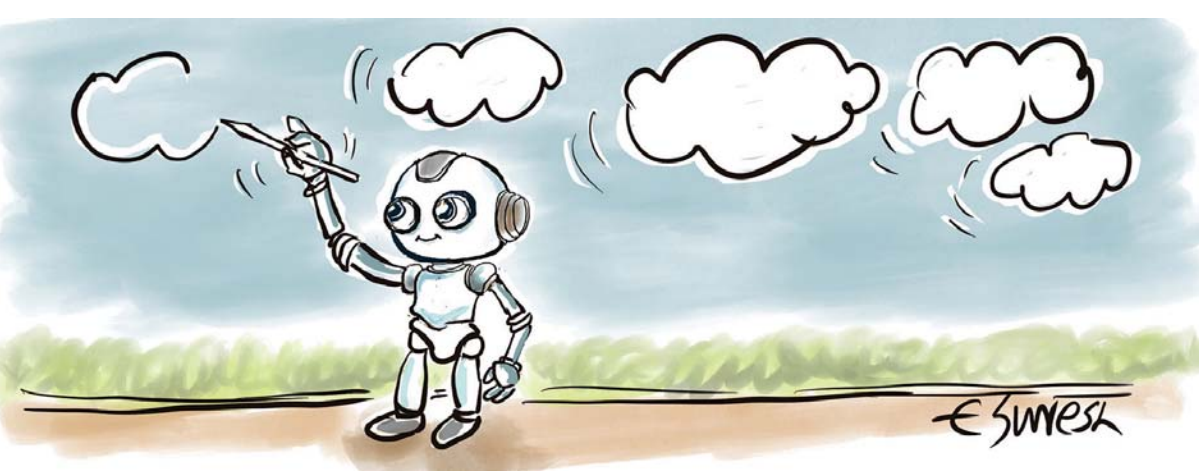
This deserves greater focus because environmental governance sits at the intersection of economic growth, climate resilience and public welfare. Decisions on water, agriculture, infrastructure, urbanisation and disaster preparedness increasingly shape India's long-term development trajectory. As environmental risks become economic risks, the quality of environmental governance will increasingly influence the quality of growth itself.

Much of the public debate on AI has focused on its environmental footprint, particularly the energy and water needed to support computing infrastructure. Those concerns are legitimate and deserve attention. But they capture only one side of the story.

An equally important question is how AI can strengthen governments' ability to understand and manage the natural systems on which development depends.

Environmental governance has long faced a challenge not of data scarcity but of data integration. India today generates enormous amounts of information on rainfall, rivers, groundwater, weather, land use and ecosystems. The challenge has been bringing these different streams of information together in ways that support timely public decisions. Valuable information exists, but it often remains fragmented across institutions and programmes.

Today, advances in satellite imagery, geospatial technologies, sensor networks, cloud computing and AI make it possible to analyse multiple environmental datasets simultaneously, identify patterns that would otherwise remain hidden and generate more timely insights for decision-making. This is more than better monitoring. It enables governments to anticipate risks, understand how different systems interact and respond before problems become crises.



THE REAL VALUE OF AI LIES NOT IN REPLACING HUMAN JUDGEMENT BUT IN HELPING GOVERNMENTS UNDERSTAND EMERGING RISKS EARLIER, SEE CONNECTIONS MORE CLEARLY AND MAKE BETTER-INFORMED DECISIONS. DATA QUALITY, INSTITUTIONAL CAPACITY AND COLLABORATION ACROSS GOVERNMENT REMAIN INDISPENSABLE

Leena Nandan is Former Secretary, Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change, and Distinguished Fellow, Earth Science and Climate Change, TERI. Suryaprabha Sadasivan is Managing Principal, Chase Advisors

Water offers perhaps the clearest illustration. India is home to nearly 18 per cent of the world's population but has only around 4 per cent of its freshwater resources. Groundwater acts as a critical buffer against monsoon variability, supporting more than 60 per cent of irrigation and around 85 per cent of rural drinking water. As climate variability increases, managing this resource is becoming more complex.

Yet decisions relating to river basins, groundwater, irrigation, urban water supply and disaster management are often informed by separate datasets, institutions and planning processes, even though water does not recognise administrative boundaries.

Integrating satellite imagery from ISRO, hydrological observations under the National Hydrology Project, groundwater assessments by the Central Ground Water Board, weather forecasts, reservoir operations and water quality monitoring into shared decision-support systems would enable policymakers to understand how river basins are evolving and intervene earlier.

Water is only one example. The same approach can strengthen air quality management, improve pollution surveillance, support ecosystem monitoring and help governments respond earlier to emerging environmental risks. Better environmental intelligence is therefore not simply an environmental objective; it increasingly shapes decisions on agriculture, infrastructure, industrial investment, urban planning and disaster resilience.

India is not starting from scratch. Platforms such as India-WRIS, the National Hydrology Project and PARIVESH have already demonstrated how digital technologies can strengthen environmental governance. The next step is to connect these capabilities rather than continue developing them in isolation.

There is a useful lesson here from India's Digital Public Infrastructure. Its success came from creating shared standards and trusted digital systems on which governments, busi-

nesses and innovators could build. Environmental governance requires a similar approach. Shared environmental data, common standards and secure data-sharing can help institutions work from a shared understanding of environmental conditions rather than fragmented information.

At its core, governance is about making decisions under conditions of uncertainty. Technology cannot eliminate that uncertainty, but it can reduce it.

The real value of AI lies not in replacing human judgement but in helping governments understand emerging risks earlier, see connections more clearly and make better-informed decisions. Data quality, institutional capacity and collaboration across government remain indispensable.

As India builds its AI ecosystem, environmental governance should be recognised as one of its priority public-sector applications. A practical starting point would be AI-enabled pilot projects in selected river basins, integrating hydrological, groundwater, meteorological and geospatial datasets into shared decision-support systems. Building on existing platforms rather than creating new institutions would demonstrate how AI can improve public decision-making and generate lessons for other sectors and states.

India has rightly set itself the ambition of becoming a global AI leader. But leadership will ultimately be measured by more than the sophistication of models or the scale of computing infrastructure. It will also depend on how effectively AI is applied to solve real public challenges.

India's first digital revolution transformed public service delivery. Its next has the opportunity to strengthen the quality of public decision-making itself. If AI helps governments better understand and manage water, air and other natural systems with greater foresight, it will not only improve environmental outcomes. It will demonstrate that AI creates its greatest public value when it helps governments govern better.

PIC TALK



Hawkers carrying colourful toys walk along the Sangam amid cloudy weather in Prayagraj.

PHOTO: PTI



RAJYOGI
BRAHMA
KUMAR
NIKUNJ JI

2ND OPINION

Despite galloping scientific achievements that mankind has witnessed, we have never been able to question the invincibility of Nature. While textbooks are filled with lessons on all kinds of natural calamities, there is still no breakthrough in any natural calamity prediction mechanism. In such a scenario, the best bet for any country to deal with such a horrendous event is to be prepared for the worst while hoping for the best.

A recent scientific study into climate change has concluded that almost all of the summer sea ice in the Arctic Ocean is likely to disappear late this century because of global warming. In India, another study has said that by the middle of the century, the sea level will increase by 24.1 cm, causing coastal floods, and there will be more cyclones in the Bay of Bengal, while the average temperature in cities like Delhi



and Mumbai will increase by three to four degrees Celsius. That prediction no longer feels distant.

It has taken many scientists long to accept the fact that the world's climate is changing because of human activity. The burgeoning human population, increasing industrial activity, deforestation and the rampant exploitation of the Earth's natural resources have altered our ecosystem irreversibly.

The devastating consequences of this are now becoming apparent. However, in spite of all these happenings, experts are unwilling to look at the bigger picture and instead offer local phenomena as the explanation. But it is obvious that the Earth's climate is changing for the worse. Nature, which has helped man live on this planet for thou-

The climate reckoning has begun

sands of years, providing sunshine, food and water, is turning harsher.

The world went agog when a country like the UAE, which is associated more with deserts, saw rare snow and hail on its northern mountain peaks a few years back. Similarly, the devastating scenes of destruction caused by the tsunami, which killed lakhs of people, showed humans how powerless they are before the forces of nature.

The lesson has not gone away with time. Dubai, the same desert emirate, was paralysed in 2024 when a year's worth of rain fell in a single day, turning highways into rivers. Each of these was called unprecedented. None of them should have been, though, because all these manifestations of nature's fury cannot be mere anomalies. It is increasingly becoming clear that they are the result of the damage done to the environment by human beings. We forget that no amount of technology or money can save us from nature's wrath when it comes.

Hence, we need to understand that it's still not too late. Even now, there is time to change our course towards more sustainable, nature-friendly practices (if we have the will to do so). It only requires a change in our mindset, from that of acquisition and consumption to one of sharing and caring. If we continue living the way we have done so far, we may very well bring bigger disasters upon ourselves, and of the kind that will change the face of the Earth.

The writer is a spiritual teacher and a columnist

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE



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RESPONSIBLE DISSENT, NOT DIGITAL CHAOS

The ongoing student protests in New Delhi over the alleged examination paper leak have generated widespread public concern. While students have every democratic right to question the authorities and demand accountability, the manner in which the issue is being amplified on social media deserves equal attention. Disturbing videos, provocative reels and sensational posts are flooding the internet, often fuelling anger rather than encouraging constructive dialogue. Such content can deepen social divisions and spread misinformation at a time when restraint is needed. It is reassuring that the Prime Minister has ordered an inquiry into the paper leak and assured students that those responsible will be held accountable. The

focus should now remain on ensuring a fair investigation and implementing long-term reforms to restore confidence in the examination system. Public protests and criticism are integral to a healthy democracy, but they must remain peaceful, fact-based and responsible. Exaggeration, fake narratives and inflammatory content only weaken social harmony and provide opportunities for hostile elements to exploit internal tensions. Students deserve justice, and the nation deserves stability. The need of the hour is calm, dialogue and decisive action rather than digital outrage that serves little purpose beyond inflaming public sentiment.

KIRTI WADHAWAN | KANPUR

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

A tragedy India must never forget

The 22nd anniversary of the Kumbakonam school fire tragedy is a solemn reminder of one of independent India's darkest days. On July 16, 2004, ninety-four innocent children lost their lives in a devastating blaze that exposed glaring lapses in school safety. Though more than two decades have passed, the grief of the affected families remains as fresh as ever. The memories of young lives cut short continue to haunt the nation's conscience and underline the heavy cost of negligence. Amid this sorrow, the remarkable journey of survivor SS Jennifer, who has cleared the Tamil Nadu Public Service Commission's Group-I examination to become a Deputy Collector, offers a powerful message of resilience and hope.

Her achievement is a tribute to her lost classmates and an inspiration to countless others who have overcome adversity. However, remembrance alone is not enough. Every school must strictly adhere to fire safety norms, conduct regular emergency drills and ensure safe infrastructure so that such a tragedy is never repeated. The greatest tribute to the departed children lies not merely in paying homage but in safeguarding every classroom across the country. Their memory must continue to inspire vigilance, compassion and unwavering commitment to children's safety.

RANGANATHAN SIVAKUMAR | CHENNAI

Reel hero, real responsibility

The release of Jana Nayagan, Vijay's farewell film as an actor, has become far more than a cinematic event. It marks a unique moment in Indian politics and cinema, as the film reaches audiences while he serves as the sitting Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu. The story of an honest leader fighting corruption and injustice has resonated strongly with audiences, reflected in record-breaking advance bookings and immense public enthusiasm. The film also places a greater responsibility on Vijay himself. The idealistic Chief Minister portrayed on screen has created expectations that his government will uphold the same values of integrity, transparency and courage in public life.

Cinema can inspire, but governance ultimately determines a leader's legacy. Citizens will judge him not by powerful dialogues or dramatic victories but by his ability to deliver good administration, honest leadership and meaningful reforms.

Winning elections may have brought him to office, but sustaining public trust will require consistent performance. If Vijay succeeds in translating his reel-life ideals into real-life governance, Jana Nayagan will be remembered not only as his final film but also as the beginning of a remarkable.

RS NARULA | PATIALA

Service beyond uniform

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A MYLSAMI | COIMBATORE

CJP protests: Long and short-term steps necessary

The controversy surrounding the paper leak and the student protests has once again exposed the widening trust deficit between the government, the Opposition and the public. While the demand for accountability is legitimate, the unrest has also reignited a broader debate on the conduct of politics, governance and electoral reforms



SUBHASH CHANDRA AGRAWAL

In mid-May, Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, presiding over an unrelated contempt hearing, described a certain kind of unemployed young Indian as a “cockroach” — jobless, chronically online, prone to attacking people on social media. It was meant as a throw-away aside. Ten weeks on, it has produced the largest sustained street challenge Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s government has faced since 2014, a paralysed Monsoon Session of Parliament, and a national argument that has long since outgrown the remark that started it.

Within a day, Abhijeet Dipke, a political communications strategist with past ties to the Aam Aadmi Party, turned the insult into satire, launching a “Cockroach Janta Party” open to anyone unemployed, chronically online and willing to rant. The joke went viral — more than twenty million Instagram followers within days — and by June it had a physical address at Jantar Mantar, where it merged with genuine student anger over two real grievances: a leaked NEET-UG medical entrance paper and chaos in CBSE’s on-screen marking and revaluation process. The demand crystallised around one name: Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, whose resignation protesters have sought since the sit-in began on June 6.

What might have stayed a campus grievance gained national heft when Sonam Wangchuk, the Ladakhi education reformer who has spent two years leading hunger strikes for his region’s Sixth Schedule status, joined in solidarity on June 28, with an indefinite fast at the protest site. His forced hospitalisation on July 18, as his health declined, appears to have been the trigger for what followed. On July 20, the opening day of the Monsoon Session, more than ten thousand protesters tried to march on Parliament; Delhi Police met them with tear gas and baton charges, and by the force’s own count, roughly 180 people were hurt — 118 police personnel and 60 protesters — with some accounts of stones thrown as the crowd was pushed back. Amnesty International questioned whether the response met basic tests of proportionality. The next day, Rahul Gandhi and Priyanka Gandhi Vadra led a sit-in outside the Prime Minister’s residence and were briefly detained; the day after, Congress MPs disrupted both Houses of Parliament, forcing repeated adjournments. The government has offered talks — Union Health Minister JP Nadda has met protest representatives — without yet meeting the central demand. Solidarity protests have since spread to Mumbai, Bengaluru, Kolkata, Guwahati, Ahmedabad and beyond, and the story has drawn the kind of sustained foreign — press attention — *Al Jazeera*, *NPR*, *Time*, *ABC News* — that Indian street protests rarely get outside election season.

There is a genuine, and genuinely difficult, argument buried under all the noise. One side notes that ministers have resigned over a single accident before: Lal Bahadur Shastri stepped down as Railway Minister in 1956 after twin train disasters, still cited as a high-water mark of accountability in Indian public life, and asks why two consecutive examination failures touching lakhs of futures should count for less.

The other side argues that a resignation extracted by street pressure, rather than institutional review, does little to fix the process that produced the leak and the marking chaos, and sets an unstable precedent for every future crisis. Both arguments carry weight. Neither explains why this fight keeps happening in the street instead of somewhere upstream of it.

That missing upstream — a routine, unglamorous channel where accountability gets settled without a hunger strike or a baton charge — is really the story beneath this one. It points towards a reform conversation that has sat half-finished in Indian politics for years, some of it quite literally in a parliamentary committee room right now.

The most advanced piece is “One Nation, One Election”. A Joint Parliamentary Committee chaired by BJP MP PP Chaudhary has spent months touring



PHOTO: PANKAJ KUMAR

THE GOVERNMENT HAS OFFERED TALKS — UNION HEALTH MINISTER JP NADDA HAS MET PROTEST REPRESENTATIVES — WITHOUT YET MEETING THE CENTRAL DEMAND. SOLIDARITY PROTESTS HAVE SINCE SPREAD TO MUMBAI, BENGALURU, KOLKATA, GUWAHATI, AHMEDABAD AND BEYOND, AND THE STORY HAS DRAWN THE KIND OF SUSTAINED FOREIGN-PRESS ATTENTION

The writer is a Guinness World Record holder for writing the most letters and an RTI consultant

states — Goa in mid-July, Lucknow next — gathering views on the Constitution (129th Amendment) Bill, which would synchronise Lok Sabha and state assembly polls. Chaudhary has said the bill is unlikely to be tabled this session but could still be ready for a 2029 rollout. Supporters point out that simultaneous polls were, in fact, the norm from 1951 until the cycle broke down in 1967, and argue that reviving it would cut the recurring cost of India’s staggered election calendar and the governance drag of a near-permanent campaign; critics, including several Opposition-ruled states, warn it would weaken federalism and hand a structural advantage to whichever party dominates the national mood in a single synchronised moment. It is a serious, contested debate, and deserves to be treated as one rather than rushed through or shelved indefinitely.

Money in politics is the second unfinished piece. The Supreme Court struck down the electoral bonds scheme as unconstitutional in February 2024, restoring at least the principle that voters have a right to know who funds their parties. In practice, financing has simply migrated to electoral trusts. Some trusts do disclose which party received what — filings for the year after bonds ended show the money heavily concentrated in a handful of trusts, with the ruling party by far the largest beneficiary — but political parties themselves remain outside the Right to Information Act, which the Central Information Commission ruled over a decade ago they should already fall under, and corporate donations, freed of the old cap tying them to company profits, remain the dominant and still murky source.

A third cluster concerns Parliament’s accountability to itself, where the record is more mixed than reformers often admit. Some ground has genuinely shifted: in 2024, a seven-judge Supreme Court bench in *Sita Soren v Union of India* unanimously overturned the notorious 1998 ruling — the one that grew out of the original JMM cash-for-votes scandal — which had treated a lawmaker’s bribe-for-vote as a protected “parliamentary proceeding”, immune from prosecution. What has not shifted: mandatory, public disclosure of MPs’ assets and pending criminal cases remains inconsistent; NOTA still carries no consequence for the candidates it rejects; and MPLADS, which lets each MP direct discretionary development spending in their constituency, continues to draw the patronage complaints it has drawn for decades, from the Comptroller and Auditor General on down.

Proposals to go further — minimum educational qualifications or fitness tests for candidates — resurface after almost every election cycle and remain genuinely contested on rights grounds; disclosure and transparency, rather than gatekeeping who may stand, is where reform energy has actually converged.

A satirical insult should not, by rights, have become the year’s defining protest movement. That it did says less about the joke than about how few other outlets existed for the grievance underneath it. None of the reforms above would by itself have prevented this particular Jantar Mantar — *One Nation, One Election* is contentious enough to invite protests of its own — but a political system that keeps rediscovering its accountability gaps through street clashes and adjourned Question Hours has more reason than most to stop treating “reform agenda” as a phrase reserved for committee rooms, and start treating it as the actual, unfinished work of this Parliament and the next.

Peace cannot be built through war



SANTHOSH MATHEW

“In war, the loudest sound is not the explosion of bombs, but the silent cry of innocent people who lose everything.”

Every war begins with promises of security. It ends with funeral processions, broken homes, frightened children and shattered economies. The ongoing conflict involving Iran, Israel and the United States is proving once again that wars rarely solve the problems they are meant to address. Instead, they often create new crises while ordinary people pay the highest price. The first justification for confronting Iran was that it was supposedly on the verge of developing nuclear weapons. But an important question remains. If building a nuclear bomb had been Tehran’s immediate objective, why did Iran sign the 2015 Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA)? Under the agreement, Iran accepted strict international inspections and reduced its stockpile of low-enriched uranium by nearly 98 per cent. A country determined to rush towards a nuclear weapon would hardly agree to such extensive restrictions and monitoring.

Iran’s Supreme Leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, repeatedly declared that nuclear weapons violated Islamic principles. Many questioned whether those statements reflected genuine policy or political strategy. That debate continues. What is undeniable is that the nuclear agreement imposed unprecedented limits on Iran’s programme and was widely regarded by many experts as the most effective mechanism for preventing nuclear proliferation. The situation changed dramatically after the United States withdrew from the agreement in 2018. The collapse of the deal weakened trust, reduced international oversight and pushed all sides towards confrontation instead of dialogue. Diplomatic bridges were slowly replaced by military calculations.

As the conflict intensified, the reasons for war also appeared to shift. At first, the world was told that military action was necessary to stop Iran’s nuclear ambitions. Later, protecting freedom of navigation through the Strait of Hormuz became the dominant argument. Ironically, the Strait had remained open before the bombing campaign began. Today, because of the war itself, that vital waterway has become one of the world’s most dangerous flashpoints. A conflict launched in the name of preventing instability has instead multiplied instability across the region.

The fighting is no longer confined to Iran and Israel. American military facilities in the Gulf have become potential targets. Bahrain, home to the United States Fifth Fleet, Kuwait, Qatar and the United Arab Emirates now face growing security risks because of their strategic partnerships with Washington. The activities of Yemen’s Houthi movement have added another layer of uncertainty by threatening shipping routes in the Red Sea. Every missile launched raises fears that the conflict may spread across the entire Gulf region.

The greatest tragedy is that civilians have no escape from the consequences. Families live under constant fear of missile attacks. Workers lose their livelihoods. Children grow up hearing air raid sirens instead of school bells. Hospitals struggle to function. Refugee numbers increase. Global oil prices fluctuate. Inflation rises. Countries thousands of kilometres away also feel the economic shock through higher fuel costs and disrupted supply chains. Modern wars no longer remain local; they quickly become global burdens.

One uncomfortable reality deserves greater attention. Every major conflict creates enormous financial opportunities for a small group of beneficiaries. Defence manufacturers receive record orders. Energy companies profit from volatile oil prices. Financial markets react to every rumour of war or peace. Speculators make fortunes from uncertainty while ordinary citizens struggle with rising living costs. This is the dark face of crony capitalism, where prolonged instability becomes profitable for a few while millions suffer its consequences.

None of this means that security concerns are imaginary. Israel has genuine security fears. Iran has legitimate concerns about sanctions, external pressure and regional isolation. The Gulf monarchies worry about their own survival. The United States seeks to protect its strategic interests and allies. These concerns cannot simply be dismissed. But history has repeatedly shown that bombs cannot permanently eliminate fear. They only postpone it until the next conflict.

What the region desperately needs is not another military offensive but another diplomatic breakthrough. Here, India has a unique role to play. India’s foreign policy has long been guided by the principles of dialogue, peaceful coexistence, strategic balance and respect for sovereignty. This spirit of Dharma Diplomacy — seeking justice without vengeance and peace without surrender — offers an alternative to endless cycles of retaliation. India enjoys goodwill across West Asia and maintains constructive relations with countries on opposing sides.

That diplomatic capital should be used to encourage negotiations rather than escalation.

The world has witnessed enough wars fought in the name of peace. Every generation promises that the next conflict will be the last. Every generation discovers that violence only plants the seeds of another war. Lasting peace cannot be built through missiles alone. It requires patience, trust, compromise and courageous diplomacy.

The Middle East does not need another battlefield. It needs another negotiating table. The international community must realise that no military victory can compensate for the destruction of human lives. Every child saved from war is a greater victory than any territory captured on a battlefield.

“The true measure of a nation’s strength is not how many wars it can fight, but how many lives it can save by preventing one.”



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India’s climate defence begins at the doorstep



GAURAV SHARMA

El Niño, a tongue-twisting Spanish term from faraway Pacific waters, is quietly shaping how we sweat in Delhi, sow in Vidarbha and shop for coolers in Jaipur. It is not the sole author of our heatwaves and erratic rains, but it is a powerful co-writer in the climate story now unfolding across India. And here lies the real question this phenomenon poses to us: will India merely endure El Niño as a passive victim of Pacific moods, or will it convert this recurring stress test into a citizen-led movement for climate resilience?

At its core, El Niño is a natural climate pattern in which warm surface waters that normally sit near Indonesia spread eastwards across the Pacific, altering the position of jet streams and monsoon-like circulations far beyond the ocean itself. It does not create every extreme event on its own, but it amplifies an already warming world, loading the climate dice towards more intense heat and more erratic rain.

For India, this is never an abstract statistic. Because large sections of our agriculture remain rain-fed, a weak or delayed monsoon

translates swiftly into crop stress, falling yields, rural distress and pressure on food prices. Our cities, concrete-heavy and tree-light, add the urban heat island effect on top of El Niño-linked heat, straining power grids and, when that demand is met through coal, feeding the very warming that will worsen the next heatwave. It is a vicious cycle. But it is also, crucially, a cycle in which citizens are not bystanders but participants who can choose which direction to push it.

India cannot switch off El Niño; it is a rhythm of the planet, not a policy failure. What India can do is refuse to let it remain someone else’s problem — a matter for meteorologists, ministries and models alone. The most durable defence against a Pacific-born disruption is not a satellite in orbit but a citizen in a colony, a village, a school, deciding that resilience begins at the doorstep.

This is where the idea of a citizen climate movement becomes not a slogan but a necessity. Resident welfare associations and ward committees can convene short “climate sabhas” ahead of forecast heatwaves or weak monsoons, mapping who among them — the elderly, outdoor workers, the urban poor — needs shade, water or shelter first. Panchayats, already custodians of tanks and commons, can revive the discipline of protecting village ponds and water bodies rather than waiting for the next drought to rediscover their worth. Schools and colleges can turn tree-planting from an annual ritual photograph into a



tracked, owned responsibility, where each sapling has a name and a guardian.

Households, too, are frontline institutions in this movement. Fixing a leaking tap, harvesting rooftop rainwater, choosing a ceiling fan

over an air-conditioner where possible, and reserving high-energy cooling for genuine need are not small gestures; multiplied across a billion-plus people, they are climate policy in their own right. India’s civilisational memory

already supplies the vocabulary for this restraint. The Ayurvedic idea of ritucharya — living in step with the seasons — and the Bhagavad Gita’s counsel of balanced consumption and action for “the welfare of the world” are not museum pieces; they are ready-made ethics for a citizen who wants to act rather than merely worry.

Media professionals, teachers and youth groups have a particular duty here: to translate El Niño from a remote meteorological curiosity into a clear, local call to action — on WhatsApp groups, community radio and morning assemblies — without tipping into alarmism or, worse, apathy. A citizen who understands why the mango crop is late or why the reservoir is low is a citizen more likely to conserve water in July rather than panic in May.

The Pacific will keep swinging between El Niño and La Niña; that is not in Indian hands. What is entirely in Indian hands is whether each heatwave and each weak monsoon is met with organised, local, citizen-driven preparation — or with the same startled scramble as before. The next El Niño need not be a rehearsal for catastrophe. It can be the moment India proves that a civilisation built on the wisdom of living with nature can also lead the world in the discipline of acting on it, one household, one ward, one village at a time.

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Delhi court denies bail in fake murder confession case



A Delhi court has declined anticipatory bail to a man accused of impersonating his brother-in-law through fake emails sent to US federal agencies, saying the allegations pointed to a serious cyber crime with international ramifications and required custodial interrogation.

Additional Sessions Judge Hargurvarinder Singh Jaggi dismissed the plea of Michael Ashish Mukherjee, saying the allegations against him went beyond a matrimonial dispute and disclosed a "highly sophisticated" cyber crime.

Mukherjee was accused of sending fake e-mails to US agencies by impersonating his brother-in-law and falsely confessing to the assassination of American political activist Charlie Kirk.

An FIR was registered against Mukherjee at Safdarjung Enclave police station here under several BNS provisions and the Information Technology Act.

In an order dated July 22, the court said, "Custodial interrogation is strictly required for the recovery of the specific digital devices used to transmit the fabricated confessions, and shielding the applicant with pre-arrest bail would practically guarantee the destruction of these digital footprints."

According to the prosecution, the complainant, Prateek Paul, a PhD scholar at Columbia University, alleged that Mukherjee created fake email IDs in his name and sent these fabricated mails to agencies, including the FBI, the US Department of Justice and the Department of Homeland Security, falsely confessing to the assassination of Kirk.

The emails allegedly contained details of Paul's passport, visa and New York ID, following which US authorities visited his residence in New York. (PTI)

HC lets adopted son cremate mother after month-long delay

The Calcutta High Court on Thursday allowed the immediate cremation of a woman's body by her adopted son, noting that the body had been lying uncremated for one month due to claims and counterclaims by relatives.

Petitioner Arka Mondal moved the high court praying for a direction to the police authorities permitting him to cremate the dead body of his mother Krishna Ghosh, who died a month ago on June 23.

It was stated that her body has been kept in the mortuary of state-run R G Kar Medical College and Hospital here.

The court noted the state Government's submission that though Mondal is the adopted son, a dispute exists between him and other family members, causing an impasse over the cremation of the body.

"What is pivotal is that a lady died on June 23 and today, July 23, a writ petition is being considered to decide who will cremate the dead body," Justice Bhattacharyya observed. The court said that cremation is necessary immediately, considering that the woman died a month ago. Justice Bhattacharyya directed the police authorities to permit the petitioner to cremate the dead body immediately, without deciding any other rights of the petitioner and the relative. (PTI)

Illegal constructions along Ganga matter of concern: SC

Observing that illegal constructions along the Ganga are a matter of concern, the Supreme Court has directed the Bihar Government to remove all unauthorised structures and encroachments between Nauzar Ghat and Nurgur Ghat in Patna along the river banks within six weeks.

A bench comprising Justices JB Pardiwala and KV Viswanathan noted that no steps had been taken by authorities to remove encroachments despite its earlier orders. "We are informed that till this date, no steps have been taken to remove the encroachments. We grant six weeks to the State of Bihar to ensure that each and every unauthorised structures/construction and the encroachments are removed between Nauzar Ghat and Nurgur Ghat in Patna.

"We direct that a compliance report in this regard by way of an affidavit shall be filed by a competent authority by the next date of hearing. Any laxity in this regard will be viewed strictly," the bench said. During the hearing, Additional Solicitor General Aishwarya Bhati sought more time to place a comprehensive report on record with regard to the illegal constructions, saying some of the states have not furnished the information. (PTI)

SC quashes bail, directs Sonam to surrender

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday set aside bail granted to Sonam Raghuvanshi, accused of killing her husband Raja Raghuvanshi during their honeymoon in 2025.

The top court allowed a plea filed by the Meghalaya Government challenging the bail granted to Sonam.

A bench of justices MM Sundresh and PB Varale granted three weeks to Sonam to surrender before police.

The apex court said in the event of trial not proceeding and concluding within six months, Sonam is at liberty to file a fresh bail application.



The accused, a resident of Indore in Madhya Pradesh, was arrested in June last year in connection with the killing of her businessman husband Raja Raghuvanshi.

The couple had gone missing while vacationing in Meghalaya's Sohra area on May 23 last year. Subsequently, Raja's body was found in a deep gorge on June 2, 2025. The police has alleged that Sonam conspired with hired assailants to kill her husband for financial gains.

Calcutta HC adjourns hearing till July 30 on Abhishek Banerjee's petition against 8 FIRs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The Calcutta High Court on Thursday adjourned hearing till July 30 on TMC MP Abhishek Banerjee's petition seeking protection from coercive action in eight FIRs lodged against him in different police stations.

The court also held that Banerjee's lawyer cannot cite Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari as an example in his case. Adjourning the matter till July 30, Justice Saugata Bhattacharyya directed Banerjee's counsel to bring to the notice of the court if any action is taken against him in the meantime in connection with the eight FIRs.

Contending that the high court had granted protection to Adhikari in 17 FIRs against him when he was the Leader of Opposition in the West Bengal assembly, Banerjee's lawyer stated that it had also then directed future FIRs could not be registered against him without



the court's permission. Senior advocate Kapil Sibal, representing the TMC MP, argued that if it was good for Adhikari, it should be good for Banerjee, too. Justice Bhattacharyya maintained that Adhikari cannot be cited as an example, stating that prayers must be taken up on a case-to-case basis.

Upon hearing the initial contention of Sibal seeking protection from coercive action by the police, Justice Bhattacharyya verbally said it cannot give protection to the Trinamool Congress leader at

SC lawyers back Jantar Mantar protest with Preamble recital

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Advocates at the Supreme Court on Thursday recited the Constitution's Preamble as part of their "Save Democracy, Save Constitution" campaign in support of the Jantar Mantar protest and opposing the police action on protesters.

Senior advocates Indira Jaising and S Muralidhar led the recitation by the lawyers during the apex court's lunch recess.

President of the Supreme Court Bar Association and senior advocate Vikas Singh was also present there. Talking to reporters, Jaising said, "We are here to stand with



the students. We are here to stand on the side of justice. We are here to demand justice for the students. We are not here to agitate for ourselves. This is not about us."

"This concerns the rights of students, and it is the duty of lawyers to stand before the Supreme Court

and demand justice for them. The role and function of the Supreme Court of India is to dispense justice. That is why we are here, in the temple of justice, with our demands," she said.

The CJP, an organic movement against paper leaks and alleged irregularities in the examination system that started with a comment from Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, referring to youngsters as "cockroaches", has been sitting at Jantar Mantar since June 20.

The protest gathered traction as activist Sonam Wangchuk and a group of students from the Left-affiliated AISA started a hunger strike.

Kerala actress assault case: HC rejects accused plea

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kochi

The Kerala High Court has declined to suspend the sentence of two accused in the 2017 actress assault case, in view of the seriousness of the crime committed by them and the manner in which it was carried out.

A bench of justices Raja Vijayaraghavan V and KV Jayakumar also took into account "the larger considerations of public interest, the societal impact of the offence, and the need to preserve public confidence in the administration of criminal justice", to deny the relief to the two accused.

The order came while dismissing the separate pleas by Saleem H and Pradeep, accused number 5 and 6, respectively, in the case. The court said that on going through the judgment and the materials placed on record, it was of the prima facie view that there was sufficient evi-



dence on record to prove the alleged conspiracy between the six accused and that they executed their plan with precision.

"Prima facie, it appears that the applicants (Saleem and Pradeep) had assisted and aided in the commission of the crime, and shared the common intention with all the conspirators," the bench said.

The two accused had sought suspension of their 20-year jail sentence during the pendency of their appeals against their conviction and punishment.

SC allows TTZ to process 400 pending MSME applications

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday permitted the Taj Trapezium Zone Authority to process around 400 pending applications for setting up non-polluting Micro, Small, and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs) in the ecologically sensitive area around the Taj Mahal.

The top court, however, directed that every proposal be scrutinised by experts from the Central Empowered Committee (CEC) and the National Environmental Engineering Research Institute (NEERI), and in case

of any objection, the application concerned "shall not be accepted without the leave of this Court".

A bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana heard the long-pending matter concerning industrial activity in the 10,400 sq km Taj Trapezium Zone (TTZ), where the court has, since 1996, imposed stringent restrictions to protect the Taj Mahal from pollution.

The bench said while key studies, including the Vision Document for the TTZ, a cumulative impact assessment and NEERI's final report



on the definition of non-polluting industries, are still pending, their pendency should not stall consideration of applications already received by the TTZ Authority.

The bench took note of the submissions of Attorney

as of now, the vision document is yet to be finalised and "the cumulative impact assessment study, in terms of the order dated April 22, 2025, is still incomplete".

It also noted that the final report on the definition of non-polluting industries is yet to be submitted.

"While all three pending initiatives are required to be completed expeditiously and within a reasonable time, we are of the considered view that the pendency thereof ought not to impede the processing of those applications which have already been received by the TTZ Authority. "What is of para-

mount importance is that the precautionary principle must be strictly followed and adhered to, with the advice and, wherever necessary, under the direct supervision of domain experts. We, therefore, direct that the TTZ Authority may process the pending applications," the bench ordered.

The bench further directed that in every meeting convened for consideration of such applications, "one expert nominated by the CEC and one expert representative of NEERI shall be invited to participate. No meeting shall be held unless both such experts are present".

Supertech twin towers: SC defers hearing on plea seeking refund for homebuyers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday deferred by three months the hearing on a plea seeking refund to homebuyers of the now-raised twin-towers of real estate firm Supertech in Noida.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana took note of the submissions that efforts were on to satisfy the claim of the homebuyers, who have not opted for alternative allotment.

The bench deferred the hearing after it was told that three months' time be given to explore other options to



satisfy the claims of the homebuyers. A lawyer, representing a few homebuyers, said they are not getting the refund and the last payment was made way back in 2024.

Earlier, the top court had said homebuyers of the now-raised twin-towers will be refunded on a pro-rata basis

SC agrees to hear Goa Congress leader's plea against defection of MLAs to BJP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday agreed to hear a plea challenging a decision of the Goa assembly speaker rejecting a petition by the Congress for disqualification of eight of its MLAs who defected to the ruling BJP in 2022.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana admitted the appeal filed by Congress leader Girish Chodankar over the defection of the eight MLAs.

"Is there any conflict of opinion between the high courts," the CJ asked while



admitting the plea for final hearing. "Post the plea for final hearing before a three-judge bench," he said.

At the outset, the counsel for the Congress leader said that 11 MLAs, who were elected on the party's symbol, went away and merged with BJP.

Senior advocate Mukul

Rohatgi said that according to the 10th schedule of the Constitution, if two-thirds of the legislature party merged with another party then it amounted to merger of political parties also.

Rohatgi said the matter needed urgent hearing as the term of this assembly will also get over.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta appeared for the office of the speaker.

The eight MLAs form two-thirds of the Congress legislative wing, which meets a provision in the anti-defection law that allows a split in such cases without the members needing to resign and contest elections.

HC seeks report from Delhi Govt on steps taken to remove stray dogs by July 31

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Thursday asked the Delhi Government and the Municipal Corporation of Delhi to file a comprehensive report on the steps they have taken to comply with the Supreme Court's directions on removing stray dogs from public spaces.

A bench of Justices Dinesh Mehta and Rajneesh Kumar Gupta passed the order on a suo motu case initiated by the high court pursuant to the top court's directions dated May 19.

The bench called for striking a balance between the interests of "dog lovers" and "dog haters", stating that every day there are cases of dog bites and it is the



common man who is troubled. It also said that monkey menace was an "even more serious" issue.

"The Government of National Capital Territory of Delhi and the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) shall file a comprehensive report in relation to the steps so far taken in compliance of directions so far passed by the Supreme

Court, and this court, up to July 31," the bench ordered. The court also issued notices to the Centre and the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) in the matter, and listed it for hearing on August 3.

On May 19, the Supreme Court directed the state Governments and Union territories to augment infrastructure to deal with stray dogs

and other animals, and asked all the high courts to register a suo moto case to ensure compliance of its August 22, 2025, and November 7, 2025, directions.

The top court has issued a slew of directions to deal with the "alarming rise" in dog bite incidents within institutional areas such as educational institutions, hospitals and railway stations.

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Farmers' income increased in recent years: EAM-PM chair

Indian agricultural growth has been the highest among the large economies in the last decade, resulting in significant increase in farmers' income, Economic Advisory Council to Prime Minister (EAC-PM) Chairman S Mahendra Dev said on Thursday. Addressing an event organised by International Chamber of Commerce, Dev said India achieved significant progress in agriculture production since the green revolution, transforming itself from a food deficit nation into one of the world's largest producers of food grains, fruits, vegetables, milk, and fisheries.

"The average growth of Indian agriculture has been close to 4.5 per cent over the last decade or so, probably the highest among the large economies of the world," he said.

Dev noted that agriculture has a share of about 17 per cent of GDP and 43 per cent in employment. He said the present government is focusing on increasing farmers' incomes instead of only on production. He said diversification and focus on high-value crops, livestock and fisheries, will help farmers get higher incomes. (PTI)

EU hits Google with \$1b fine over its app store, search

The European Union (EU) on Thursday hit Google with a fine of 890 million euros (\$1 billion) after it said the technology behemoth broke digital antitrust regulations by setting up Google Play and its ubiquitous search engine to corral consumers towards its own services and apps to the detriment of competitors.

It was the latest major crackdown on Big Tech by Brussels, which has led the world in reining in some of the world's largest companies from Silicon Valley to Beijing. Google had recently lost its appeal of a \$4.5 billion antitrust fine imposed for throttling competition and reducing consumer choice through the dominance of its mobile Android operating system.

The European Commission, the bloc's executive branch, said it was acting in the interest of consumers. "The best products should succeed because they're better, not because they're owned by the company running the search engine. And European consumers have a right to be told by app developers where to sign up to the best offers, even when the app store owner does not get a cut," said Teresa Ribera, the commission's Executive Vice President for Clean, Just and Competitive Transition. (PTI)

CENTRE CLEARS FDI TO BOOST EXPORT-BASED E-COMMERCE

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Government on Thursday permitted FDI in an inventory-based model of e-commerce "exclusively" for export purposes, a move which will help increase India's outbound shipments without impacting the businesses of small retailers.

"In order to facilitate greater exports through easier and increased access of global markets by Indian sellers, the extant FDI Policy has been reviewed and it is decided that the restrictions on inventory-based model of e-commerce shall not apply in case of exports of domestically manufactured and/or produced goods/products," the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT) said in a Press Note.

As per the consolidated FDI (foreign direct investment), FDI is permitted in Business to Business (B2B) e-commerce and marketplace model.

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | FRIDAY | JULY 24, 2026

India fastest-growing major economy: ITC Chief

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India's multidimensional policy interventions have enabled the country to emerge as the fastest-growing major economy in the world even as global volatility becomes "systemic" rather than sporadic, said ITC Chairman and Managing Director Sanjiv Puri.

Addressing shareholders at the company's Annual General Meeting (AGM) on Thursday, Puri said the crisis in West Asia has had a severe impact on the global economy, and that recent global developments only reinforce the view that turbulence today is systemic rather than sporadic.

"The prolonged uncertainty arising from the West Asia crisis has severely impacted

the global economy, threatening energy security and trade. Indeed, the multitude of events in the recent past only reinforce the fact that global volatility is no more sporadic; it is now systemic," he said.

Against this backdrop, Puri said, the Prime Minister's vision for an Aatmanirbhar Bharat and a Viksit Bharat has taken even greater significance, spurring multidimensional policy interventions that have helped India emerge as the fastest-growing major economy in the world.

"It has inspired multidimensional interventions enabling India to emerge as the fastest-growing major economy in the world," he said.

"The far-reaching measures announced in successive Budgets have provided strong

foundations to unleash growth. India's ascent is not merely about outpacing other large economies," Puri added.

It has demonstrated that a nation of continental scale, democratic depth and extraordinary diversity can drive

momentum with stability, pursue reform with inclusion, and convert aspiration into resilient growth.

Recalling his remarks from last year, when he had described the prevailing environment as an era of "TURN"

Is listing the only road to good governance?

Reserve Bank of India move to list Upper-Layer NBFCs raises an old question in a new form

The Reserve Bank of India's decision to require fifteen Upper-Layer NBFCs to list their shares has revived an old debate in a new form. The conversation around Tata Sons Private Limited is only the most visible part of it. The deeper question is this: when a regulator wants better governance from the entities it supervises, is mandating a stock exchange listing the only instrument to reach for?

The answer is not obvious, and it deserves more careful thinking than it has received. Listing is, at its core, a capital markets mechanism. It helps a company raise money from the public. It also gives existing shareholders a way to convert their holdings into tradeable instruments. In that sense, the capital market allows public savings to participate in private enterprise. The governance requirements that come with listing serve a narrower purpose. Disclosure, transparency, board oversight, and related-party restrictions are meant to protect investor funds.

RBI's purpose in directing Upper-Layer NBFCs to list is not likely to be capital raising. Some of these entities are already well-capitalised. They may have no commercial need for public funds. The objective appears to be governance. The idea is that listing will impose disciplines that improve how these institutions are run. That is a reasonable instinct. But it is also an indirect way to reach the goal.

How the equating happened

SEBI's mandate has always been to protect investors, and it has used governance as the principal instrument to do so. With the original Clause 49 of the listing agreement in 2000, SEBI effectively became the benchmark for corporate governance in India. Other regulators fol-

lowed, modelling their frameworks on what SEBI had built for listed entities. Listing, which exists for capital, came to be treated as synonymous with governance, which exists for trust. The two are related, but they are not the same thing.

Whose decision is it?

The decision to list, in ordinary corporate law, belongs to the shareholders of a company. A company cannot migrate from privately held to publicly listed without the consent of at least three-fourths of its shareholders by value. Minority shareholders can ask, but they cannot compel. Majority shareholders can resist, and their resistance is legally protected. When a regulator mandates listing, it overrides this shareholder prerogative. This is not, in principle, an objection to the regulator's authority, regulators can and do mandate compliance with all manner of obligations when public interest justifies it. The question is whether listing is the appropriate instrument, or whether the same governance objective can be achieved through less invasive means.

Is there an alternative?

The cleanest alternative is to require Upper-Layer NBFCs to comply with governance provisions of SEBI's LODR Regulations directly, without insisting on listing. This is not hypothetical. Stock exchanges themselves were required

to comply with LODR governance norms even when they were unlisted. Companies that raise substantial funds through debt securities are required to follow LODR governance provisions. The toolkit for imposing listed-company disciplines on unlisted entities already exists.

Along with the above, Upper-Layer NBFCs can be asked to submit secretarial audit reports and annual secretarial compliance reports directly to RBI. These third-party assurance documents would give the regulator a continuing, independent view of how each entity is actually governed, without the structural consequences that follow from a listing.

What listing brings with it

When an entity is required to list, it acquires the entire architecture of public-market obligations, several of which have nothing to do with governance. Confidentiality obligations around price-sensitive information. Supervision by additional regulators. Mandatory disclosure of material events as they occur. Majority-of-minority voting on transactions where promoters and related parties cannot vote. The objective is governance, not listing.

None of this is to argue against governance. Upper-Layer NBFCs play a meaningful role in the Indian financial system, and the case for holding them to the highest governance standards is straightforward. The case for using listing as the route to those standards is less so. The instruments are available. Governance provisions from LODR can be applied, and secretarial audits, compliance reports can be mandated. The governance outcome can be achieved without forcing entities whose business purpose is not capital formation into the capital markets.

Both RBI and the affected entities are working toward the same end. The conversation worth having now is about which instrument best serves it, and the Indian regulatory toolkit has more in it than this single choice suggests.

The writer is managing partner, Makarand M Joshi & Co

BUSINESS 11

— marked by Turbulence, Uncertainty and Rapid change — Puri said this reality has become even more pronounced as deeper structural shifts reshape the future of nations, societies and businesses. He said the situation calls for novel strategies to help enterprises reimagine their approach to the future.

However, Puri also added that as India ascends on the global stage, Indian businesses must reimagine their strategies not only to navigate the TURN but also to seize the emerging opportunities.

In his speech, Puri highlighted that, despite the challenging operating environment, ITC had delivered positive results over the medium term. Its "net Segment Revenue, currently at over Rs

83,300 crore, grew at a CAGR of 10.7 per cent and EBITDA at 9.7 per cent over the last 5 years," he said, adding now "Non-cigarette businesses constitute nearly two-thirds of net segment revenue."

Moreover, over the last five years, ITC has distributed nearly ₹85,000 crore to shareholders by way of dividends.

"Foreign exchange earnings of the ITC Group over the last 5 years aggregated nearly US\$ 6.5 billion, of which agri exports constitute over 60 per cent," demonstrating ITC's contribution to the rural economy, he said.

Its FMCG business, which was around ₹14,720 crore in FY21, now has crossed the ₹24,200 crore mark in FY26, with sustained improvement in profitability.

Steel industry must look for new markets: Govt official

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Indian steel industry must diversify, look for new export markets, and accelerate decarbonisation to remain globally competitive, a government official said on Thursday. The trade landscape is shifting as many countries are taking protective measures to safeguard their industries, Ashwini Kumar, Economic Advisor, Ministry of Steel, said.

"Indian steel industry must accelerate decarbonisation, strengthen technology and R&D, and diversify its export markets to remain globally competitive amid a rapidly shifting trade landscape shaped by carbon border measures and tariff actions," he said addressing ASSOCHAM's India Steel Conclave 2026 in the national capital.

The US and the EU have both taken measures to support their industries. While the US have invoked Section 232, the EU has introduced measures like CBAM (Carbon border adjustment mechanism) to avoid steel manufactured through high-carbon-emission processes.

CBAM means that market access in high-value destinations will increasingly depend not only on the quality and price of the steel, but also on

the carbon intensity of the production process. Given the high carbon intensity of Indian steel, it will become difficult for Indian steel exports to the EU, he noted.

"I would like to look at it with a positive lens, an opportunity to modernise India's steel industry, improve technology and production processes, significantly reduce emissions and, at the same time, strengthen its long-term global competitiveness.

I am confident that with the right policy support, continuous innovation, investment in technology and close collaboration between government and industry, the Indian steel sector will not only overcome these challenges but emerge stronger and more globally competitive," Kumar said.

Tushar Makkar, Head, Corporate Communications, ArcelorMittal Nippon Steel India (AMNS India), highlighted the need for uninterrupted supply of raw materials amid global situations.

"Raw material security continues to be a strategic concern. India remains dependent on imports for approximately 85 per cent of its coking coal requirements, exposing producers to supply-chain disruptions, freight volatility, geopolitical risks and raw-material price fluctuations," he said.

Wipro Consumer to acquire Good Home, EVA Brands for ₹256 crore

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Wipro Consumer Care & Lighting will acquire Good Home and EVA brands from TTK Healthcare in a Rs 256 crore deal, expanding its play in the fast-growing home and personal care segments.

The FMCG arm of Azim Premji-led Wipro Enterprises signed definitive agreements on Thursday, according to a joint statement.

In a regulatory filing, Chennai-based TTK

Healthcare said it expects the sale to be completed by September 30, 2026, subject to fulfilment of conditions

precedent. "The total value of the consideration is ₹256 crore plus applicable GST," it said.

IndiGo posts ₹238 crore net loss in three months

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

IndiGo on Thursday reported a ₹238 crore net loss for the three months ended June as higher fuel prices and the West Asia conflict resulted in turbulence for the country's largest airline.

The airline had a profit of ₹2,176.3 crore in the year-ago period.

In the first quarter of the current fiscal, InterGlobe Aviation saw its total income rise to ₹25,614.1 crore from ₹21,542.6 crore a year ago. However, overall expenses

surged during the same period, according to a release. "A combination of fuel price escalation, adverse foreign exchange movement and the Middle East conflict impacted profitability during the quarter, resulting in a net loss of ₹2.4 billion," it said.

Markets extend losses to 4th day as crude prices surge

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Market benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty ended lower on Thursday, extending losses for the fourth straight session, as a sharp jump in crude oil prices due to escalating tensions in West Asia weighed on investor sentiment.

The 30-share BSE Sensex declined 363.66 points, or 0.47 per cent, to settle at 76,391.39. During the day, it tanked 603.07 points, or 0.78 per cent, to 76,151.98.

The 50-share NSE Nifty dipped 126.65 points, or

Index	Open	High	Low	Close	Change	% Change
NSE Nifty	23,904.80	23,990.75	23,807.20	23,869.60	-126.65	-0.53%
BSE Sensex	76,515.10	76,726.66	76,151.98	76,391.39	-363.66	-0.47%

0.53 per cent, to end at 23,869.60.

From the Sensex pack, Adani Ports, Bajaj Finance,

InterGlobe Aviation, Axis Bank, State Bank of India and Tata Steel were among the major laggards.

Rupee slips 4 paise to settle at 96.57 against US dollar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The rupee declined 4 paise to close at 96.57 (provisional) against the US dollar on Thursday, as heightened hostilities in West Asia kept global crude oil prices elevated.

However, a likely intervention by the RBI provided support to the local unit, forex traders said.

At the interbank foreign exchange, the rupee opened at 96.53 and traded in a narrow range of 96.45-96.59 during the day before eventually settling at 96.57 (provisional), down 4 paise

from its previous close.

The rupee depreciated by 28 paise to close at 96.53 against the US dollar on Wednesday.

"The rupee traded with a negative bias on weak domestic markets and surge in crude oil prices, which continued to rise as the US struck Iran for the 12th consecutive day while Iran continued to strike US facilities in the Gulf," Anuj Choudhary, Research Analyst, Mirae Asset ShareKhan, said.

"However, diplomatic talks between the two nations may prevent sharp fall in the rupee. USD-INR

Date	Rate (₹ per US \$)
16	96.42
17	96.30
18	96.42
19	96.36
20	96.36
21	96.25
22	96.53
23	96.57*

spot price is expected to trade in a range of ₹96.30 to ₹96.85," Choudhary said.

FROM THE WORLD

PAKISTAN

Gunmen kill judge, guard

A Pakistani judge was killed and another injured when their convoy was attacked by unidentified gunmen in the Mastung area of Pakistan's Balochistan province on Thursday. District and Sessions Judge Abdul Hakeem Kakar and his guard were killed on the spot. Judge Kakar and Additional Sessions Judge Tariq Lashari were travelling from Quetta, the capital of Balochistan, to Mastung for court hearings when their vehicles came under attack, Shahid Rind, spokesperson for the Balochistan government said. Judge Lashari was among the two injured in the attack, he said. (PTI)

PALESTINE

Food insecurity eases in Gaza

The world's leading authority on food insecurity said on Thursday that the situation in Gaza had improved since famine was declared in parts of the Palestinian territory last year, but warned that conditions remained at crisis levels. The Integrated Food Security Phase Classification, or IPC, said a reduction in fighting as well as Israel allowing more aid into Gaza had driven improvements. But the IPC noted that food consumption remained inadequate. The designation underscored how conditions in Gaza have both markedly improved since last year and remain at crisis levels. (AP)

Yemen's Houthis attack Saudi tankers in Red Sea

ELENA BECATOROS/ FATMA KHALED/ COLLIN BINKLEY ■ Cairo

Yemen's Iran-backed Houthi rebels said they attacked two Saudi oil tankers in the Red Sea on Thursday, potentially opening a new front as the US military conducted its 12th night of strikes against Iran.

The Houthis have threatened to shut down another key trade route, with the world economy already reeling from Iran's closure of the Strait of Hormuz. Iran and the US have meanwhile stepped up their attacks as they vie for control of the strait, through which a fifth of the world's oil and gas passed in peacetime, setting off a scramble for alternative routes.

US President Donald Trump threatened "major military punishment" against the Houthis if their attacks on ships continue. "If they



do this again, the US will hold Iran responsible, in that the Houthis are a Surrogate and/or Proxy of Iran, and major military punishment will be inflicted upon Iran and, of course, the Houthis themselves," Trump wrote on social media.

As the rhetoric escalated, so did the economic fallout. The price of a barrel of Brent crude oil, the international standard, spiked 4.3 per cent Thursday to USD 98.16, its highest level since early June, before the two sides reached a pre-

liminary peace agreement that has since collapsed.

Prime Minister Ali al-Zaidi of Iraq, who has close ties to both the US and Iran, was in Tehran on Thursday to call for peace and dialogue, a spokesperson said. Al-Zaidi met with Trump earlier this month in Washington.

An Arab diplomat said Gulf states are increasingly pessimistic about finding an off-ramp. The diplomat, speaking on condition of anonymity due to the sensitivity of the situation, said regional countries, in addition to Pakistan and Türkiye, continue to push for de-escalation.

The Houthis' SABA news agency said the rebels had struck two tankers, the Encelia and the Layla, in the Red Sea, leading to fires on both. There were no reports of casualties. (AP)

US CONGRESS PASSES RESOLUTION SEEKING TO HALT MILITARY ACTION IN IRAN AGAIN AS SOME REPUBLICANS DEFECT

Washington: The House on Thursday narrowly passed a resolution to halt US military action in Iran, sending a warning to President Donald Trump for the second time as the war has escalated and the future of the conflict is increasingly uncertain.

The 214-208 vote requiring congressional approval for the war comes as the Senate is expected to consider a similar resolution later Thursday morning. Though the votes forced by Democrats are largely symbolic, they are meant as a strong signal to the Republican president that his support on Capitol Hill is chipping away as the war drags on and lawmakers in both parties have questioned his administration's



endgame. The war has had "no clear mission, no strategy, no end goal," said Washington Rep. Pramila Jayapal, a Democrat who led the resolution on the House floor. The resolution narrowly passed after a handful of Republicans voted with Democrats to end the war. But the vast majority of Republicans voted to back the war and cede congressional war powers to Trump. (AP)

Pak vows retaliation against any attack on its vessels

SAJJAD HUSSAIN ■ Islamabad

Pakistan on Thursday vowed "swift" retaliation to any hostile act against vessels carrying its flag or maritime interests in the Red Sea, warning that such acts will be regarded as "grave threats" to its national security.

Office Spokesperson Tahir Andrabi's remarks at a weekly press briefing came after Yemen's Iran-backed Houthi rebels attacked Saudi oil tankers in the Red Sea earlier in the day. Andrabi said that any attack against Pakistani-flagged vessels or against its commercial vessels will be "treated as an attack against Pakistan and will be swiftly retaliated" against. The hostile act will be regarded as a grave threat to its national security, he said, adding: "We will do so in our



Tahir Andrabi

exercise of self-defence."

Pakistan has so far avoided being drawn into the armed conflict despite a defence agreement with Saudi Arabia.

Andrabi "unequivocally" condemned the continued threat by the Houthis against Saudi Arabia and commercial shipping in the Red Sea, saying this endangers regional security, freedom of navigation and global trade. (PTI)

EAM meets Omani counterpart, discusses West Asia situation

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Manila

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar on Thursday met his Omani counterpart Sayyid Badr bin Hamad Al Busaidi and discussed the West Asia crisis as well as the evolving regional landscape.

Jaishankar, who is in the Philippine capital Manila, also met with the foreign ministers of the Netherlands, Papua New Guinea and Brunei, as well as other leaders on the sidelines of meetings related to the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN).

The external affairs minister also called on the Philippines President Ferdinand R Marcos Jr. Jaishankar's meeting with Al Busaidi came amid renewed tensions in West Asia with the US and Iran escalating military activity. While American forces are targeting Iran's bridges, water desalination plants and electrical facilities, Tehran, in turn, is



External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar during a meeting with Oman's Foreign Minister Sayyid Badr bin Hamad Al Busaidi in Manila, Philippines

hitting US bases in allied countries throughout West Asia. "Appreciated meeting with FM Sayyid Badr bin Hamad Al Busaidi of Oman in Manila," Jaishankar said in a

post on X. "Exchanged perspectives on the recent developments in the Gulf region. Agreed to remain in touch," he said. In a social media post, Al

Busaidi said, "Excellent catch up with @DrSJaishankar. Productive discussions on the evolving regional landscape and the need for sustained engagement to

address shared concerns and challenges."

In his meeting with the Philippines president, Jaishankar conveyed the greetings of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and India's support for a successful chairship of the ASEAN.

"India-Philippines cooperation under the aegis of our Strategic Partnership continues to diversify as we implement the India-Philippines Plan of Action 2025-2029," Jaishankar said on X.

He also met his counterpart from the Netherlands, Tom Berendsen.

"Followed up with FM Tom Berendsen @ministerBZ on the outcomes from PM @narendramodi's recent visit to the Netherlands. The elevation of our ties to a Strategic Partnership has opened new avenues of cooperation, including in semiconductors, water resources, green hydrogen, health & culture," he said.

The Pioneer

Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Bimla Devi, Mother of JC-472477Y Sub Kuldeep Singh, R/o- Vill & PO- Chaharwala, Teh- Nathusari Chopta, Distt- Sirsa Haryana-125110, have changed my name from Bimla Devi to Bimla, vide affidavit dated 23/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(273)C I, Meena Pathania W/O Suresh Singh R/O Qtr No-P-02/02, New APS Colony, Delhi Cantt- 110010 declare that name of mine has been wrongly written as Meenu in my minor daughter namely Sparsh Pathania aged 13 years in her school record. The actual name of mine is Meena Pathania which may be amended accordingly.

PD(274)C I, Guljar, Mother of- No.15215000N L/Hav (OPR) Rafi Shaik, R/o- DR No.- 22-3-47, Vill/Post & PS- Ponnur, Dist- Guntur, Andhra Pradesh- 522124, have changed my name from Guljar to Shaik Guljar Begum, vide Affidavit dated 23/07/2026 Before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(275)C I, JC-343433K Nb Sub Anil Siwach, R/o- VPO- Bhaini Surjan, Teh- Meham, Dist- Rohtak, Haryana- 124112, have changed my daughter's name from Manashvi to Manashvi S Siwaach, vide affidavit dated 23/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(276)C I, JC-343433K Nb Sub Anil Siwach, R/o- VPO- Bhaini Surjan, Teh- Meham, Dist- Rohtak, Haryana- 124112, have changed my son's name from Divyansh to Divyaash S Siwaach, vide affidavit dated 23/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(277)C I, Ashoke Kr Garal, Father of No.17000434Y Hav Soumendra Nath Garal, R/o- Kantaria PO- Kshiragram, P-S- Katwa, Dist- Purba Bardhaman, West Bengal- 713143, have have changed my name from Ashoke Kr Garai to Ashok Garai vide affidavit dated 01/07/2026 before SDM Purba Bardhaman.

PD(278)C

सार्वजनिक सूचना
राजेश्वर सिंह (आधार नं० 5463 9655 7104) पुत्र श्री सन्तपाल सिंह निवासी पकानि नं० 19ए, एण्ड 19बी, खसरा नं० 32-19, ग्रह फ्लोर अवधवल नगर पार्क-1, निलीडी एक्सप्रेसवे निलीडी रोड दिल्ली-110041 का निवासी हूँ जो कि निम्नलिखित हस्तक्षेपण कराल हूँ कि:-
1. यह है कि मैं उत्प्रेक्षा पत्र का स्वामी निवासी हूँ।
2. यह है कि मेरा बेटा हेमराज सिंह व यह वर्षा मेरे कानून के अनुसार हैं और मेरी बात नहीं मानते हैं और अपनी सामग्री करते हैं।
3. यह है कि मैं अपने बेटा हेमराज सिंह व यह वर्षा को अपनी बात व अर्थव्यवस्था में बेवजह कराल हूँ।
4. यह है कि मेरा बेटा हेमराज सिंह व यह वर्षा मेरे कोई भी अधिकार में लेते-देने कराल यह खुद स्वयं विमर्शकारी होगा इसमें मेरे व मेरे किसी भी परिवार को कोई भी जिम्मेवारी नहीं होगी।
5. यह है कि मेरा बेटा हेमराज सिंह व उत्प्रेक्षा पत्र का स्वामी निवासी हूँ।
आय दिन हमारे साथ छोटी-छोटी बातों को लेकर लड़खड़ाता व बार-बार करते रहते हैं जिससे मुझे व मेरे परिवार को जान माल का खर्चा है।
6. यह है कि उत्प्रेक्षा पत्र जारी व दुर्कल है।
तत्पश्चात् तत्पश्चात् की जाती है कि मेरे द्वारा दिया गया वस्तु सही व दुर्कल है इसमें कोई भी तथ्य नहीं छिपाया गया है।
स्थान:-
दिनांक :- 22-07-2026

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given that my client, Kapil Dev Sharma, is in process to Purchasing the Built-Up Property bearing No. 302, Area Measuring 108 Sq. Yds., i.e. 90-30 Sq. Mtrs., out of Kharsa No. 111, situated at Village Mouppur in the abadi of Gali No. 10, Adarsh Mohalla, Krishna Gali No. 10, Mouppur, Ilaga Shahdara, Delhi-110053, from Keshav Yadav, by executing the Sale Deed from Tata Capital Housing Finance Ltd. That Keshav Yadav acquired the said property vide Relinquishment Deed dated 8/7/2025 Doc no.2025/23/IL/5383 executed by his sisters Rajani Yadav and Kalpana. My client has informed us that the following original documents pertaining to the said property are not available with his seller and for the same he already lodged an FIR dated 22/7/2026 in lieu of that.
1. Original GPA, ATS, and WILL, dated 28/11/1994 executed by Shyam Singh Yadav in favour of Kamta Prasad Mirza
All persons having any claim against or in respect of the said Property, or any part thereof, by way of sale, exchange, mortgage (equitable/registered or otherwise), gift, trust, inheritance, family arrangement, lease, sublease, tenancy, license, lien, charge, pledge, easement or otherwise whatsoever, are hereby requested to notify the same in writing to us with supporting documentary evidence at the address mentioned below within 7 days from the date hereof, failing which the claim or claims, if any, of such person or persons will be considered to have been waived and/or abandoned.
Kamali Kant Gupta (Advocate)
Unit No. FF-2, First Floor, Mahalaxmi Tower, Sec-4, Vashi, Gzb., UP. Mob 9810063351

PUBLIC NOTICE
NOTICE is hereby given that Archana Verma & Simmi Sethi (hereinafter called the Seller/s) claims to be owner and in possession of Third Floor With 50% Share of Roof Rights, of Prop No. 1093, Kingsway Camp, Dr. Mukherjee Nagar, Delhi-09 (Said property) after the death of Krishan Lal Sachdeva who executed a Will dated 20.10.2017 regd. vide Doc. no. 2790 in favor of the sellers & said Krishan Lal Sachdeva was the owner of the said property by virtue of Partition Deed dated 08.06.2015, regd. vide Doc. no. 6282 RW Conveyance Deed dated 28.03.2014, regd. vide Doc No.47918 now Seller/s has agreed to sell the said Property to Geeta Devi & said Geeta Devi has agreed to create a mortgage in favour of our clients Axis Bank Ltd., Janak Puri Branch, N.D., any person's having claim against the said Property, or any part thereof, by way of sale, exchange, mortgage (equitable/registered or otherwise), gift, trust, inheritance, lien or otherwise however, are hereby intimated to notify the same in writing to us with supporting documentary evidence at the address mentioned below within 10days from the date hereof, failing which the claim or claims, if any, of such person or persons will be considered to have been waived and/or abandoned and our client shall proceed with the disbursement of loan and subsequent creation of mortgage in respect thereof.
Vishal Diwan (Advocate)
Diwan & Company
Ho.No.2 (LGF), NRI Complex, N.D-19
Email: vishaladiwan@diwanandcompany.com

कार्यालय नगरपालिका परिषद दमोह (म.प्र.)

क्र./न.पा./2026/1814

दमोह, दिनांक 22/07/2026

निम्नलिखित कार्य हेतु केंद्रीयकृत प्रणाली मे पंजीकृत ठेकेदारों से अधोलिखित विवरण अनुसार दर पर ऑनलाइन निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है। निविदा का विस्तृत विवरण www.mptenders.gov.in पर देखा जा सकता है।

क्र.	टेण्डर नं.	कार्य का नाम एवं विवरण	अनुमानित लागत	निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य एवं अमानत राशि	अंतिम तिथि
1.	2026_UAD_523525_1	सी एम माॅनित A+ योजना अंतर्गत नगर पालिका परिषद दमोह मे विभिन्न स्थानों पर निर्माण एवं अधोसंरचना विकास कार्य। (द्वितीय निविदा आमंत्रण)	Rs. 436.62 लाख	15000/- 219000/-रु	10/08/2026

मुख्य नगरपालिका अधिकारी

नगर पालिका परिषद दमोह

पू.क्र./न.पा./2026/1814/1



SMFG
Grihashakti
Nagji Roha, Nagji Vishwas.

SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd.
 Corporate Off.: 503 & 504, 5th Floor, G-Block, Inspire BKC, BKC Main Road, Bandra Kurla Complex, Bandra (E), Mumbai - 400051.
 Regd. Off.: Commerzone IT Park, Tower B, 1st Floor, No. 111, Mount Poonamallee Road, Porur, Chennai - 600116, TN

SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTIES					
E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE OF 15 DAYS FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE ASSETS UNDER THE SECURITISATION AND RECONSTRUCTION OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND ENFORCEMENT OF SECURITY INTEREST ACT, 2002 READ WITH PROVISION TO RULE 9(1) OF THE SECURITY INTEREST (ENFORCEMENT) RULES, 2002. NOTICE is hereby given to the Public in General and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below listed immovable properties ("Secured Assets") mortgaged / charged to the Secured Creditor, the Possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd. (hereinafter referred to as SMHFC) ("Secured Creditor"), will be sold on "As is where is", "As is what is" and "Whatever there is" on the date and time mentioned herein below, for recovery of the dues mentioned herein below and further interest and other expenses thereon till date of realization, due to SMHFC Secured Creditor from the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) mentioned herein below.					
Sl. No.	Name of the Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s) LAN	Description of the Properties	Reserve Price : Earnest Money Deposit :	Date & Time of E-Auction	Date of EMD Submission
1.	LAN : 605439211152649 1. Anand Kashyap 2. Manju 3. Vikas Bholanath	Flat No. UFG-5, On Upper Ground Floor, Back Portion LHS Admeasuring 554 Sq. Ft. Without Roof Rights Built On Free Hold Plot No. B-3 & B-4, Total Land Admeasuring 368 Sq. Yds. Kharsa No. 1207 Situated At Hayat Enclave, Village : Loni Pargana & Tehsil : Loni, Ghaziabad, UP-201 103.	Rs.12,10,000/- Rs. 1,21,00,00/-	13.08.2026 at 11.00 a. m. to 01.00 p. m.	12.08.2026
2.	LAN : 609139211833923 1. Shadab Mirza S/o. Aslam Mirza 2. Taramum Mirza W/o. Shadab Mirza	Flat Bearing No. FF-06 On First Floor, Rear Side RHS Referred To As The "Said Flat" of Residential Plot Bearing No. B-133, B-134 & B-135 Area Measuring 100-100-100-300 Sq. Yds, Falling In Kharsa No. 311, Situated In Rail Vihar Sakhari Awas Samiti Ltd., Hadbast Village Sadullabad, Pargana & Tehsil Loni, Dist. Ghaziabad (UP) (Hereinafter Referred To As The "Said Property"). Boundaries (As Per Technical) - East : Entry & Flat No. FF-02; West : Vacant Plot; North : Vacant Plot, South : Staircase.	Rs.8,90,000/- Rs. 89,00,00/-	13.08.2026 at 11.00 a. m. to 01.00 p. m.	12.08.2026
3.	LAN : 620639211888272 1. Anuraadha Singh 2. Rahul Kumar	Residential Ground Floor, RHS Witout Roof Righs, Built On Plot No. 71, Area Measuring 470 Sq. Feet Out Of Kharsa No. 223, Situated At Block B, Nearby Rail Vihar Gate, Rail Vihar, Shekhari Awas Samiti Ltd. Hadbast Village Sadullabad Pargana & Tehsil Loni, Dist. Ghaziabad.	Rs.14,50,000/- Rs. 1,45,00,00/-	13.08.2026 at 11.00 a. m. to 01.00 p. m.	12.08.2026
4.	LAN : 613938011765656 1. Jitender Jaint 2. Meenu Jaint	Flat (Without Roof Rights) Plot No. B 42, Kharsa No. 217 Area Measuring 316 Sq. Ft. i. e. 29.36 Sq. meter., In Rail Vihar Colony Tehsil : Loni, Dist. Ghaziabad, UP. Bounded As Under - East : Plot No. B-41; West : Plot No. B-43; North : Plot No. 77; South : Rasta 30 FL Wide	Rs. 89,90,000/- Rs. 89,00,00/-	13.08.2026 at 11.00 a. m. to 01.00 p. m.	12.08.2026
5.	LAN : 613939211679466 1. Kamal Chand Sonkar, S/o. Dallas Chand Sonkar 2. Rama Dai Chand W/o. Dallas Chand Sonkar	Residential Flat Bearing No. SF-2, On Second Floor, Front Middle Side, Covered Area Measuring 467 Sq. Ft. "Said Flat", Built On Property Bearing No. B-81, (Area Measuring 260 Sq. Yds.), Out Of Kharsa No. 218, Situated At Rail Vihar Sekhari Awas Samiti Ltd., Village : Saddullabad, Pargana Loni, Dist. Ghaziabad, (U. P.); (Hereinafter Referred As The Said Property). Boundaries - East : Vacant Plot; West : Plot No. B-80; North : Rasta; South : Plot No. B-38.	Rs.15,00,000/- Rs. 1,50,00,00/-	13.08.2026 at 11.00 a. m. to 01.00 p. m.	12.08.2026
6.	LAN : 613939211685714 1. Pushpender Singh 2. Rekha Rani	Residential Flat Bearing No. GF-3, On Ground Floor, Rear RHS Witout Roof Rights Said Flat Built On Plot Bearing No. A-153, Area Measuring 280 Sq. Yds., Out Of Kharsa No. 346/1, Situated At Rail Vihar Sekhari Awas Smiti Ltd. In The Area of Village : Sadullabad Paragana and Tehsil Loni Dist. Ghaziabad Up Boundaries - East : Other Property; West : Plot No. A-54; North : Other Property; South : Road 30 Ft. Wide	Rs.16,60,000/- Rs. 1,66,00,00/-	13.08.2026 at 11.00 a. m. to 01.00 p. m.	12.08.2026

Details terms and conditions of the sale are as below and the details are also provided in our/secured creditor's website at the following link website address (<https://BidDeal.in> and <https://www.grihashakti.com/pdf/E-Auction.pdf>) The Intending Bidders can also Contact : Ashish Kaushal, Mobile: 8527134222, E-mail : Ashish.Kaushal@grihashakti.com, Mr. Niloy Dey, on his Mob. 8655619157, E-mail : Niloy.Dey@grihashakti.com

Place : Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh
Date : 23/07/2026
Sd/-
Authorized Officer,
SMFG INDIA HOME FINANCE CO. LTD.



HARYANA STATE POLLUTION CONTROL BOARD,
REGIONAL OFFICE, PALWAL
PUBLIC NOTICE

The Haryana State Pollution Control Board, Regional office, Palwal, Haryana, hereby issues a public notice for the open auction of approximately "52" Yorkshire pigs. An official closure order was issued against the piggery farm operated by Sh. Devender, S/o Sh. Giriraj, located in Village Behrola, Palwal as the unit was found to be non-compliant with prevailing municipal and environmental laws, posing a risk to public health. However, the unit owner failed to comply with the stipulated 60-day timeline and is continuing to operate the farm unlawfully.

DETAILS OF THE OPEN AUCTION:
Date: Monday, 03 August 2026
Time: 11:00 am
Location: Piggery farm of Sh. Devender S/o Giriraj, Village Behrola, Palwal

Interested buyers may inspect the pigs at the sealed Behrola farm on August 3, 2026, between 10:00 AM and 2:00 PM. The livestock will be sold strictly on an "as-is-where-is" basis with a minimum price of Rs 100/kg. To participate, bidders must submit a letter of interest to the Regional Officer, Haryana State Pollution Control Board, Regional office, Palwal before bidding begins. Upon full payment, the buyer will be solely responsible for arranging the safe and legal transportation of all pigs from the farm within twenty-four hours at their own expense. The Haryana State Pollution Control Board, Regional office, Palwal, Haryana, reserves the right to cancel or modify this auction at any time without prior notice.

ISSUED BY:
Regional Officer, Haryana State Pollution Control Board,
Regional office, Palwal.

PUBLIC NOTICE

We, Jagmohan Gupta & Shalini Gupta hereby give a notice to the general public that original Conveyance Deed No 3275 dt 25.07.89, Possession Letter dt 25.07.89 & Allotment Letter dt 03.10.85 relating to the property HNO 769A Block B Palam Vihar Gurgaon have been lost/misplaced. An original FIR dt 20.07.28 has been lodged with the Haryana Police regarding the loss. We wish to create a mortgage on the above property for a Home Loan facility from State Bank of India, Branch HLC 3 Gurgaon Code: 65154. Any person having any claim or possession of the said original documents may inform us at 9958824814 or SBI Branch.

PUBLIC NOTICE

If anyone finds the said documents, please contact the mobile number given below to return them. A suitable reward will be given, and the information will be kept strictly confidential.

Contact:
NAME : अनिल कुमार तिवारी
Mobile : 9625571229

PUBLIC NOTICE

In The Pioneer Newspaper our publication was published on dated 22-07-2026 in Page No. 12/2 that the Mr. Arinder Kohali and Mr. Jagdeep Singh Narula intends to transfer the ownership of above said flat by way of Sale Deed to Mr. Sumit Kapoor and Mrs. Kanika Kapoor. However, the Sale Deed will be executed in favour of Mr. Sumit Kapoor and Mrs. Kanika Kapoor instead of mentioned as Mr. Sumit Kumar and Mrs. Kanika Kapoor. Please read Mr. Sumit Kapoor and Mrs. Kanika Kapoor are in the process of mortgaging the said flat with Jio Credit Ltd. from the date of this public notice. Borrower Name as Mr. Sumit Kapoor and Mrs. Kanika Kapoor who are purchasing and Mortgaging the First Floor, without roof right, "said Floor", Property Bearing no. W-2229, area measuring 130 Sq. Yds, Built-on Plot no. B-214, out of Kharsa no. 449, Situated in the area of Village Tihar and the Colony Known as Fateh Nagar, New Delhi with Jio Credit Ltd.
Law Veritas: North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-44/A, Sector-36, Noida, Uttar Pradesh- 201301; Landline(s): +91020-3101683 / 4562809; e-mail: accounts@lvnoida.in

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given that all ORIGINAL PROPERTY DOCUMENTS (ALLOTMENT LETTERS, BUILDER- BUYER AGREEMENT, DEMAND LETTERS/ INVOICES, ORIGINAL PAYMENT RECEIPTS etc.) for the under construction Flat Number C-1/304 in Sun Breze Project of Unitech Ltd in Sector 69 of Gurgaon, Haryana jointly owned by Ruchi Setya and Late Sumil Kumar Setya have been lost/misplaced from parental residence at C-608 Sai Baba Society, Sector 5, Rohini Delhi - 110 085 and are now not traceable. A formal police report has been lodged with Delhi Police District ROHINI/CRIME BRANCH at PRASHANT VIHAR, DELHI under Report No 468418/2026 dated 21.07.2026. Any person finding the documents or having any claim, lien, objection, or interest in the said property is requested to notify the builder or the undersigned within 14 days of the notice.
Ashok Kumar Munjal (Authorised Attorney of Ruchi Setya), 33 Sangam Apartments (Near Ambika Vihar) Paschim Vihar Delhi 110087 Mobile + 91 9757338011 email: ruchisetya@gmail.com, Phone no. 1 412 613 3843 / 9312594128



PNB Housing Finance Limited
Finance Limit
Ghar Ki Baat

Regd. Office: 9th Floor Anfrilsh Bhawan, 22, K. G. Marg, New Delhi-110001
Ph.: 011-23445200, Website: www.pnbhousing.com CIN No.: L65922DL1988PLC033856

NOTICE FOR SHIFTING OF PREMISES TO WHOMSOEVER IT MAY CONCERN

This is the notice to the General Public that we are shifting Following Office Premises on or before 26th October, 2026

CURRENT ADDRESS
PNB Housing Finance Limited, H-1A/10, First Floor, Sector-63, Noida, Gautam Budh Nagar, Uttar Pradesh-201309
NEW ADDRESS (POST SHIFTING)
PNB Housing Finance Limited, 2nd floor, Kharsa No. ME-31, Village Mamura, Tehsil Dadri, Gautam Budh Nagar, Uttar Pradesh - 201301
Sd/-, Authorised Officer, PNB HOUSING FINANCE LIMITED

What little is known about Botom Uz comes from a government program known as the National Reparations Program, which collected testimonies of abuse. (AP)

PROSPECT

Startup ecosystem to reach every district: CM Saini



Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Wednesday said the State Government is ushering in transformative reforms in the industrial sector to translate the vision of 'Haryana Vision @2047' into reality. He directed officers to promote startups in every district and ensure that entrepreneurs do not face any administrative hurdles while setting up new businesses. The Chief Minister was chairing a review meeting at the Civil Secretariat on the Vision to Action Plan under Haryana Vision @2047 with the officers of the MSME Department, Industries Department, Startup Haryana and the Haryana State Industrial and Infrastructure Development Corporation (HSIIDC).

The Chief Minister directed officers to develop a dedicated Wood Zone and Wood Market at Barwala, complete with modern showrooms. He said the initiative would enhance the income of local artisans and generate substantial employment opportunities. He further directed officers to prepare a calendar for organising Swadeshi Melas across every district of the State. Self-Help Groups (SHGs) engaged in the production of Rakhis will be integrated into the initiative on a large scale, and their products will be linked to leading global e-commerce platforms such as Walmart and Amazon to expand their market reach. To further improve the ease of doing business, the Chief Minister said the formation of the State Innovation and MSME Council and the Startup Advisory Council Haryana.

(PNS)

Kamrup holds awareness drive on VB-GRAM-G



A District-Level Panch Sanmelan to sensitise Panchayati Raj Institution (PRI) representatives on the provisions and implementation of the Viksit Bharat – Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) Act, 2025 (VB-GRAM-G) was held on Thursday at the Conference Hall of the District Commissioner's Office, Amingaon. The programme was attended by the District Commissioner, Kamrup, Deba Kumar Mishra, along with officials and Panchayati Raj Institution representatives from across the district.

The District Commissioner provided an overview of the objectives and vision of the VB-GRAM-G initiative, highlighting its role in strengthening rural livelihoods and accelerating inclusive development. He encouraged Panchayat representatives to undertake development initiatives, ensure the protection and maintenance of community assets, uphold transparency in implementation, prepare comprehensive action plans, constitute effective monitoring and review committees, and ensure the timely execution of approved works for the benefit of rural communities.

(PNS)

A tribute to Income Tax Department



MITALI MADHUSMITA

A nation is built on the taxes its citizens pay. Income tax was first imposed on 24th July 1860; a princely sum of ₹30 lakh was collected. Tax remained a popular source of revenue for the colonial Government, often to fund imperial wars.

From a maximum marginal rate of 91.8 per cent in 1957 till it stabilised at around 30 per cent in 1997, Income Tax has grown leaps and bounds. In FY 2025-26, Direct Tax collections reached ₹23.40 lakh crores, i.e. 69 per cent of total tax revenue of ₹33.85 lakh crore, excluding borrowings. Income tax is pivotal for constructing stable and equitable societies, funding crucial public services and government investments, thus fostering growth and creating jobs. Taxation balances wealth accumulation and redistribution, promoting fairness and social cohesion. Significantly, the Income Tax Department (ITD) has graduated from a 'sovereign right to collect' to a 'taxpayer first' approach.

On 24th July this year on 'Aaykar Diwas', ITD celebrates 167 years of service to the nation. Typically, officers and staff will celebrate through outreach programs, tree planta-

tion drives, blood donation camps, etc. It would be in the fitness of things to present a snapshot view of how ITD has evolved. A NIPFP study concludes that the tax reforms in India, unlike others, were not shaped by multilateral agencies but largely by domestic considerations yet conforming to international best practices. In the last millennium, regional computer centres at 36 stations handled PAN allotment, taxpayer grievances and mapped jurisdiction. These were consolidated into the TAXNET Project in 2007.

That year, when AI & ML tools were not common, ITD launched ITDMS project creating 360° taxpayer profiles using data mining tools. This project won PM's Award 2010 for excellence in Governance and Administration PAN linkage with AADHAR was undertaken in 2017 to eliminate duplication. Delays in manual issue of PAN, processing of tax-paid challans & ITRs led to outsourcing of PAN, TIN and CPC TDS for integration of TDS/JCS with third party information, e-filing and processing of tax returns in CPC-ITR, and e-payment of taxes through TIN 2.0. The numbers of TDS/JCS statements processed annually by CPC TDS, stand at a mind boggling 1.41 crores. Similarly, CPC ITR 2.0 processed more than 8 crores ITRs filed in FY 2025-26. With growth in digital economy, predictive AI tools and BI platforms (Project Insight) are used to sift through gargantuan high

value financial transaction data shared by third parties, for strategies that enable precise enforcement, effective fraud detection and voluntary compliance.

The Faceless Assessment and Appeal Schemes were introduced in 2019 and 2020 respectively, eliminating human and discretionary contact in the conduct of assessment & appeals. Data analytical models now de-duplicate, cross reference and pre-populate returns to facilitate ease of filing Income Tax returns. The e-Verification scheme 2021 resolves high value transaction mismatches by taxpayers. Advance Pricing Agreements between the tax administration and a taxpayer determining, in advance, the Arm's Length Price are another feather in the cap of ITD, thereby bringing tax certainty for 5 and maximum 9 years. 815 APAs have been signed till 31.03.2025. An encouraging sign of trust in the system, is the keenness of MNEs to renew such APAs.

ITD regards taxpayers as inherently honest but cannot ignore those who game the system. When for example, tax breaks claimed on electric cars & disabilities far exceeded the number of such cars and disabled population, NUDGE approach was adopted to encourage such persons to update/revise their returns and pay correct taxes. This included undisclosed overseas assets and taxes on overseas income. The success of this cam-

paign is self-evident; claims on account of donations to political parties fell by 47 per cent, medical insurance claims by 49 per cent and education loan claims by 76 per cent between FY 2023-24 to FY 2025-26.

Importantly, ITD successfully nudged taxpayers to adopt the new regime. From 21 lakh taxpayers for AY 2022-23 the numbers opting for new regime have exponentially grown in just 3 years to 7.24 crores for AY 2025-26, ensuring seamless compliance and fewer disputes.

In last 2 decades, ITD has transformed through self-analysis and course correction. One area of concern of Parliamentary Committees, C&AG, etc is the huge backlog of appeals pending before Commissioner (Appeals). Most appeals are generated in the faceless assessment scheme. The mitigation measures include restoration of powers to set aside for AOs to examine afresh, roping in more manpower to dispose these appeals, closer supervision & monitoring of appellate work.

However, these steps have had limited success & the backlog of appeals continues. Although CBDT continuously refines and ensures assessment of highest risk cases, there is potential for being conservative in authorising further appeals and acknowledging mistakes, if they occur.

Another issue is the burgeoning demand standing in the ledgers of

ITD. The CAG Report No. 14/2024 recommends several steps to ensure there is no duplication, write off is pursued, focus on high-risk cases etc. These are under consideration and implementation. A big step is the establishment of the Demand Facilitation Centre.

The problem needs to be addressed at the source vis-a-vis risk management strategy so that mule accounts, prospective insolvency cases etc are tackled pragmatically, by raising red flags. Review of write off & functioning of Tax Recovery Officer by seniors, review of the CPC algorithm functioning by independent Committees are some steps that can be considered.

Given the tech-driven foundational changes, a critical part of the modernisation paradigm is a comprehensive reorganisation of the Department's human capital. A formal cadre restructuring exercise, last conducted in 2013, is a vital mechanism needed to redeploy officers into highly specialised verticals like predictive data analytics, risk management, enforcement and expedited dispute resolution. Aligning the department's institutional hierarchy with its digital transformation will fully empower the workforce to deliver the seamless, non-intrusive, and taxpayer-first administration envisioned by the new Income Tax Act 2026.

The writer is retired Indian Revenue Service officer

Climate crisis is not a technical problem, it is a collapse of values: Shyam Saran

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

Former Foreign Secretary Shyam Saran on Thursday said something that cut through the familiar language of net zero targets, carbon trading, and renewable energy mandates.

Addressing a gathering of intellectuals at the India International Centre (IIC), Saran said the world had already crossed the 1.5 degree Celsius threshold, that the net zero concept is essentially a "sleight of hand" that creates the illusion of progress while emissions continue, that Europe's response to record heatwaves has been to ask for more air conditioning. And that what humanity is facing is not a climate emergency but an ecological emergency, one that can only be resolved through a civilisational response, not a technological one, he said.

Ambassador Saran was the keynote speaker at Bharat Ki

Soch's Mantrana event on Climate Change and Sustainability in media partnership with *The Pioneer*. Bharat Ki Soch Chairperson Anil Rajput opened the discussion, and Saran, who is also the IIC President, delivered the keynote address that shaped the two hours that followed.

Former Union Minister Meenakshi Lekhi, Bharat Ki Soch Director RK Pachnanda, and *The Pioneer* newspapers and magazines group Chairman Prashant Tewari were also present on the occasion.

The framing Saran chose was deliberately broader than the standard climate discourse. He said climate change is one symptom of a larger ecological emergency involving dying oceans, disappearing forests, soil degradation, and biodiversity collapse, all of which are interconnected through feedback loops that modern thinking, divided into disciplines and specialisations, is structurally unable to



Former Foreign Secretary Shyam Saran, Bharat Ki Soch Director RK Pachnanda, Bharat Ki Soch Chairperson Anil Rajput and India International Centre Director KN Shrivastava

PIONEER PHOTO

see. "We have lost the ability to see the interconnectedness of things," he said.

On the 1.5 degree target, which the Paris Agreement set as the aspirational ceiling for global warming above pre-industrial levels, Saran was blunt. "We have already crossed it," he said. A 2019 IPCC report had warned that crossing 1.5 degrees would unleash what it called "climate

mayhem." That threshold, he noted, has been consistently overshoot since 2024.

His critique of the net zero concept was pointed. He explained that net zero by 2050 does not mean zero emissions. It means that whatever gases are still being emitted in 2050 will be balanced by carbon sinks, including forests and oceans, and by carbon capture technology.

The problem, he said, is that both major carbon sinks are being degraded.

He pointed to Europe as an example of what he called "collective blindness." When temperatures crossed 40 degrees Celsius across multiple European countries in recent weeks, the public response was not a demand for faster climate action. It was a demand for more air condi-

tioning, which will generate more emissions and accelerate the very warming that created the problem.

On technology, Saran was sceptical rather than dismissive. He noted that data centres required for artificial intelligence expansion consume vast quantities of both power and water, adding to resource pressures in the short term even if AI eventually offers solutions to climate challenges. He quoted astronomer Martin Rees to dispense with the idea of Mars as an escape route: "It is a dangerous delusion to think that space offers an escape from Earth's problems."

Rajput, in his opening remarks, noted that this year Europe has already experienced one of the most severe heatwaves in its recorded history, with temperatures crossing 43 degrees Celsius in France, and that estimates suggest more than 20,000 lives may have been lost to this summer's extreme heat across the continent.

DAILY SUDOKU

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

SOLUTION (23.7.26)

1	3	7	5	9	8	4	2	6
5	6	8	4	2	3	9	7	1
4	9	2	7	1	6	5	3	8
8	7	6	2	3	9	1	5	4
9	5	1	6	7	4	3	8	2
2	4	3	1	8	5	6	9	7
3	8	4	9	6	7	2	1	5
6	2	9	8	5	1	7	4	3
7	1	5	3	4	2	8	6	9

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
FRIDAY | JULY 24, 2026

ACROSS

21. Foreigner
23. Tin
24. Tugs
26. MOT
27. Fray
29. Stag
32. Due
33. Fauna
34. Canals
35. Entrance
36. Forest

DOWN

1. F-lags
2. Brood
3. He-re
4. M-th-S
5. Knot
6. Ransom
9. Hating
11. Low
12. Bacon
13. Capital
15. Ere
16. Per

18. A-R-tful
20. Tessa
21. Fit
22. Guy
23. To-bag-O
25. Ran
28. Reset
30. Turns
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32. Date
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SOLUTION (23.7.26)

21. Foreigner
23. Tin
24. Tugs
26. MOT
27. Fray
29. Stag
32. Due
33. Fauna
34. Canals
35. Entrance
36. Forest

1. F-lags
2. Brood
3. He-re
4. M-th-S
5. Knot
6. Ransom
9. Hating
11. Low
12. Bacon
13. Capital
15. Ere
16. Per

18. A-R-tful
20. Tessa
21. Fit
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23. To-bag-O
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28. Reset
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31. Games
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India to host International Type 1 Diabetes Summit 2026 in Jodhpur



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Friends of Mewar, in collaboration with Breakthrough T1D and the William J Clinton Foundation, have announced that the International Type 1 Diabetes Summit 2026 will be held from July 30 to August 1 in Jodhpur.

The three-day summit will bring together endocrinologists, policymakers, researchers and patient advocates from the US, Australia and across India to deliberate on equitable Type 1 Diabetes care. The announcement comes as Type 1 Diabetes in children has received formal recognition in India's national health policy, expected to boost focus on early diagnosis and affordable treatment.

Padmaja Kumari Parmar, founder of The Friends of Mewar and Global Ambassador for Breakthrough T1D, said, "This summit is an invitation to translate awareness into action and policy. Behind every diagnosis is a child and a family who deserve support."

Key discussions will cover insulin access, diabetes technology, mental health and digital innovation. The host city for the 2027 summit will be announced in Jodhpur.

CM Saini chairs district public relations and grievance committee meeting in Sirsa

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Thursday chaired the meeting of the District Public Relations and Grievance Committee in Sirsa, where he heard public grievances relating to various departments. Of the 19 complaints placed before the committee, 18 were resolved and disposed of on the spot, while one complaint was deferred to the next meeting. Former Governor of Odisha, Prof Ganesh Lal, was also present.

Parmjeet Singh, a resident of village Ganga, complained that Sultan Singh of village Jhutti Khara had died on June 11, 2000, had never married, and that his 40 kanals and one marla of land had allegedly been transferred through a forged will. The Chief Minister directed that the matter be investigated by the Vigilance Department. Earlier, the case had been examined by the District Revenue Officer.

The Chief Minister also ordered an inquiry into the solar panels installed by M/s Som Corporation, Hisar. The matter was raised during the meeting by Vinod Kumar of village



Gudia Khara, who stated that despite applying on December 18, 2024, and making the required payment, the company

neither installed the solar panels nor refunded the amount. Similar complaints regarding the same company and alleged irregularities in solar panel installations were also brought before the meeting.

The Chief Minister directed action against the police official found at fault in connection with a complaint filed by Kamlesh Kaur of Dhani Satnam, Rania police station area, in an assault case.

कार्यालय मेलाधिकारी कुम्भ मेला-2027, हरिद्वार

फोन नं० 01334-224457 Email: procure.kumbhmela2027@gmail.com

पत्रांक: 913 दिनांक 23 जुलाई 2026

मेलाधिकारी, कुम्भमेला 2027, हरिद्वार के सफल संचालन हेतु मेलाअधिष्ठान एवं विभिन्न विभागों के कुम्भ मेला क्षेत्र के विभिन्न सेक्टरों में कुम्भ मेले के दौरान 4 माह के लिये लगने वाले टैन्टों हेतु फर्नीचर, टैपेस्ट्री एवं मिसीलेनियस आइटम् के क्रय एवं किराये के आधार पर मदवारदरों की सील बन्ध (Sealed) कोटेशन (Quotation) नियमित रूप से रख-रखाव एवं संचालन हेतु विभिन्न दक्ष फर्मो से कोटेशन बन्ध पेटी के माध्यम से दिनांक 04 अगस्त, 2026 अपराह्न 05:00 बजे तक मेलाधिकारी कार्यालय में रखे सील बन्ध कोटेशन बॉक्स के माध्यम से प्राप्त की जाएंगी। उक्त कोटेशन समिति के द्वारा उपस्थित निविदादाताओं/प्रतिनिधियों के समक्ष नियत तिथि व समय पर खोली जायेगी, उपरोक्तकार्य की समय-सारिणी निम्नवत् है:-

Quotation Document प्राप्त करने की तिथि (कार्य दिवस में)	कार्यालय से दिनांक 24.07.2026 अपराह्न 5:00 बजे
Quotation Document जमा करने की अन्तिम तिथि	कार्यालय में दिनांक 04.08.2026 को अपराह्न 05:00 बजे तक
Quotation Document खोले जाने की तिथि	दिनांक 05.08.2026 को अपराह्न 12:00 बजे तक

अपर मेलाधिकारी
कुम्भ मेला-2027, हरिद्वार

verka

THE PUNJAB STATE COOPERATIVE MILK PRODUCERS FEDERATION LTD.
SCO 153-155, SECTOR 34-A, CHANDIGARH-160022, EPABX NO. 0172-5041812,66
Notice Inviting e Tender

e- tender is hereby invited for the supply of following items :-

Name of Work/Item	Period/Tentative Qty
For Verka Ludhiana Dairy Supply of printed laminated film for packing SMP in 500 gm and 1 kg.	Annual Rate Contract

NOTE:

1. For complete details regarding above tender (NIT), please visit our website i.e. www.verka.coop & e Tendering portal i.e. eproc.punjab.gov.in.
2. Corrigendum, if any, will be uploaded on website only.

1018/12/2026-27/13608

General Manager (Purchase)

BRIEFLY

Germany: Klopp expected to be named next coach



The German soccer federation has called a news conference for Friday when it is expected to present Jurgen Klopp as the next national coach. In a brief announcement on Thursday, the federation didn't give a reason for the event scheduled for Friday morning at its Frankfurt headquarters. The former Liverpool manager has been the preferred candidate ever since Julian Nagelsmann resigned following Germany's shock loss on penalties to Paraguay in the World Cup round of 32. Klopp held talks with Germany officials in New York while working there as a TV expert at the World Cup, and the federation said on July 11 they reached an agreement on "essential key points" of a contract. At that time, the main obstacle was getting the agreement of drinks giant Red Bull, where Klopp has been working for the last year and a half as head of global soccer, overseeing the network of Red Bull-backed clubs around the world. Klopp hasn't coached since he left Liverpool in 2024, citing fatigue. He said this month he felt "recharged" and ready for another job. (AP)

F1 Sim Racing India Open 2026 Time Trials from July 30



Mumbai Falcons Racing Limited (MFRL) will host the F1 Sim Racing India Open 2026 Time Trials, a talent hunt programme, here later this month to give aspiring racers an opportunity to showcase their race craft. The event will be held at Bharat Mandapam on July 30 and August 1. The Delhi Time Trials are part of MFRL's nationwide talent identification programme. The competition carries a total prize pool of ₹2 crore, the organisers said. The winner will earn a place in Mumbai Falcons Racing Limited's "One in a Billion Hunt", which features a ₹3 crore Driver Development Fund to support their journey into professional motorsport. "The F1 Sim Racing India Open trials give aspiring racers the opportunity to experience professional F1 simulators first-hand. It allows them to discover their potential and decide if they want to pursue a structured motorsport journey, progressing through the zonal and national stages of the championship and, ultimately, earning the opportunity to take their first steps into professional karting," said Ameet Gadhoke, MD MFRL. The event is contested on F1 25, the official game of FIA Formula One World Championship. (PTI)

France expected to announce Zidane as its new coach early next week

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Paris

France's new coach will be announced next Tuesday, when Zinedine Zidane is widely expected to replace Didier Deschamps.

The French Football Federation said in a statement on Thursday that its president Philippe Diallo will name the coach at a news conference at the headquarters in Paris. The 54-year-old Zidane has not coached since leaving Real Madrid in 2021. The midfield great coached Madrid to three straight Champions League titles from 2016-18. Deschamps was in charge of France for 14 years and stepped down after the



World Cup, where Les Bleus lost in the semifinals to Spain. France won the World Cup under Deschamps in 2018 and lost the final on penalties in 2022. Les Bleus also lost the European Championship final on home soil in 2016.

Zinedine was France's playmaker when it won the

rational speaker to motivate his players, and the move has already yielded encouraging results, with India winning the FIH Nations Cup this year to earn promotion back to the elite FIH Pro League for next season.

"...There is an inspirational speaker, who talks about scaling bigger mountains like Kilimanjaro. Our bigger goal is to get a medal at the 2028 Olympics, and for that we have to work towards getting to our first base camp. Out first base camp was the FIH Nations Cup and qualifying for the World Cup. If you need to reach the top every time you need to reach the base camp first. We are climbing that mountain together and we are reaching for the stars and if you reach for the stars you will fall on the highest mountain," Marijne told PTI in an exclusive interview.

The real star for me is to finish on the podium in 2028. "That is a process, that is

Will leave lasting legacy with 2030 CWG: Mandaviya

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Glasgow

Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya on Thursday said India is committed to leaving a "lasting institutional legacy" when it hosts the centenary edition of the Commonwealth Games in 2030 at Ahmedabad.

Addressing the Commonwealth Sports Ministers Meeting here, Mandaviya urged for a stronger, member-driven framework for Commonwealth sports.

"As the host of the 2030 Centenary Commonwealth Games and the 13th Commonwealth Sports Ministers Meeting in



Amdavad, we are committed to delivering an exceptional Games, while leaving behind

a lasting institutional legacy for Commonwealth sport," he said in a release issued by

Sports Ministry.

Mandaviya also outlined the governance reforms,

CWG weightlifting quota reduced due to doping violations; Dilbagh withdrawn

APARAJITA UPADHYAY
■ Glasgow

Weightlifter Dilbagh Singh has been withdrawn from India's Commonwealth Games contingent after the country's quota was reduced because of multiple Anti-Doping Rule Violations (ADRVs) during the qualification period.

India's weightlifting quota for the Games has been cut from 16 to 11. The Indian Weightlifting Federation had named a 12-member squad, spearheaded by Olympic silver-medallist Mirabai Chanu, for the showpiece and said it was told about the reduced quota



only on Wednesday. "The federation got to know about the reduction of quota from 12 to 11 lifters only yesterday," a well-

placed source told PTI. "Since Dilbagh is suffering from a back injury and did not train at all during the preparatory camp in Birmingham, a decision was made to withdraw him," he said. N Ajith (71kg), Sairaj Pardeshi (88kg) and Harcharan Singh (110kg) were banned for doping ahead of the CWG.

Woman lifter Vanshita Verma (86kg) was also sanctioned for an anti-doping rule violation in the qualification period. The reduction in quota is another setback for Indian weightlifting, which has repeatedly faced sanctions because of doping offences. (PTI)

Yashdeep Siwach carries mother, Pritam's legacy to WC

MONA PARTHSARATHI
■ New Delhi

Former India women's hockey captain Pritam Rani Siwach walked onto the field at the 1998 World Cup in Utrecht long before her son, Yashdeep, was born.

Nearly three decades later, destiny has brought the family full circle.

Yashdeep is set to make his senior World Cup debut in the very same country where his mother represented India. And when he steps on the field, it will make the Siwachs the first known mother-son duo in Indian hockey to feature at the sport's biggest tournament. The 26-year-old defender has been named in India's squad for the World Cup, to be held in the Netherlands (Amstelveen) and

Belgium (Wavre) from August 15 to 30, turning the tournament into an emotional milestone for the family.

"When I got selected, the first person I told was my mother. She became quite emotional because she had also played in the World Cup in Utrecht in 1998," Yashdeep told PTI. "For me, representing India in the World Cup in the same country where my mother played is something very special."

Pritam, one of India's finest midfielders, captained the national team and was part of the side that won the historic gold medal at the 2002 Commonwealth Games in Manchester. Although India finished 12th at the 1998 World Cup, she scored twice against South Korea. Long before he donned the India



jersey, Yashdeep's introduction to hockey came through his mother's memories. At home, he often leafed through albums filled with photographs from her playing days, observing the action shots, team pictures

and tournament moments, unaware that one day he would create a similar collection of his own.

"She has a complete album with action photographs, tournament pictures and team photos. I've been

strengthened anti-doping framework, and flagship initiatives such as Khelo India to nurture grassroots talent. He also said India strongly supports the plan to establish a Commonwealth Sport Coordination Forum as an annual platform to translate ministerial decisions into action. "India would be pleased to host meetings, technical workshops and regional consultations in the lead-up to 2030," he said.

Mandaviya reaffirmed India's readiness to host the 2030 Games, stating that Ahmedabad is fully prepared to deliver a historic, sustainable, and memorable edition of the Games. He also endorsed the proposed lead-

ership model under which the incoming host nation of the Commonwealth Sports Ministers Meeting would serve as Chair, with the President of Commonwealth Sport serving as Co-Chair. "India will be honoured to assume the Chair of CABOS for the 2026-2030 cycle," he said. Mandaviya urged Commonwealth nations to strengthen partnerships.

"Let us build institutions that endure, strengthen collaboration that delivers results, and harness the transformative power of sport for future generations. India reaffirms its commitment to safe, inclusive, and equitable sport systems that respect human rights and create opportunities for all," he said.

Rohit, Venkata power India U19 to 211-run win in 2nd Youth Test

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Colombo

Leg-spinner Rohit Yadav and pacer C Venkata shared seven wickets among them as India U19 subdued Sri Lanka U19 by 211 runs on the fourth day of the second Youth Test here on Thursday.

India U19 won the two-match series 1-0 after the first contest ended in a draw. It was a spirited comeback from Indians after they lost the preceding Youth ODI series 1-2.

Starting the day on 155 for four, chasing a distant target of 472, the home side was folded for 260 in 76.5 overs,



shortly into the post-lunch session. Skipper Vimath Dinsara, overnight 55, was the first to depart for 64, falling to pacer Pranav Raghavendra.

It was the last nail on Sri Lanka's hopes to at least extend the fight.

Rohit Yadav (4/49), who backed the three-wicket haul of Venkata (3/27) the

previous evening, soon ran through the lower order to reduce SL U19 to 242 for nine. There was a token fight from Sethmika Seneviratne (42, 49b, 6x4, 1x6) which only delayed the inevitable. Off-spinner J. Hemuchudeshan brought an end to Sri Lanka's innings and the match, dismissing Seneviratne.

looking at them since childhood. I am also in touch with many of her former teammates and keep getting guidance from them," he said.

Initially drawn to swimming, Yashdeep gradually gravitated towards hockey. He accompanied his parents to national championships and watched the 2010 World Cup in New Delhi from the stands. His childhood, however, was also shaped by the realities of having an international athlete as a mother. National camps often kept Pritam away from home for months at a stretch, in an era before smartphones and video calls.

"When I was very young, mom used to stay away for long camps. There were no video calls then. My father and grandparents looked

after me, but whenever I missed her, he would take me to meet her if the camp was in Patiala or somewhere nearby," Yashdeep recalled.

"I also remember going to the airport to see her off whenever the team travelled abroad. Once, before an Olympic qualifier tour, my father took me to the hotel and I got to spend an entire day with her."

Only after becoming part of the national camp himself did he fully appreciate the sacrifices behind his mother's career. "I didn't understand it as a child, but now I know how much hard work and sacrifice it takes to be and stay in the national team. It is difficult just to make the squad, and even harder to perform consistently for so many years," he said. (PTI)

Trent Bridge to kick off 2027 Ashes as England hosts Australia

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ London

Trent Bridge in Nottingham will host the first 2027 men's Ashes Test between England and holder Australia. The five grounds had already been selected — including

Southampton's Rose Bowl for the first time — and the dates were revealed on Thursday.

The first Test is scheduled from June 18-22. England has won its last three Ashes tests at Trent Bridge, the most recent in 2015 after Australia was bowled out for 60.

Lord's stages the second Test from June 30-July 4.

There's a scheduled break of only four days to the third Test at Edgbaston in Birmingham from July 8-12. The fourth Test marks

Southampton's men's Ashes debut from July 21-25. It becomes the 10th British ground to host a men's Ashes Test. The series ends at The Oval from July 29-Aug. 2.

There was contention that Nottingham was the most northerly venue in England in the 2027 Ashes after Old Trafford in Manchester and Headingley in Leeds were not selected.

Both grounds have been chosen for the 2031 series but when the 2027 venues were picked in 2023, the mayors of Greater Manchester and West Yorkshire wrote to the England and Wales Cricket Board to express their disappointment. Ben Stokes, who plays for Durham in the far north of England, said when he was leading England



during their ill-fated 4-1 Ashes defeat in Australia earlier this year that no Ashes tests in the north next year was "a shame." Old Trafford will stage a warmup game for

Australia against the England Lions. It is scheduled for June 7-10, which will be revisited if Australia reaches the World Test Championship final. That final at The Oval is set for June

9-13. The women's Ashes between England and Australia will run alongside the men's.

Their series begins with a women's test at Headingley for the first time since 2001 from June 24-27 followed by three Twenty20s and three one-day internationals ending on July 20.

Also announced for 2027 were England men hosting Pakistan for five ODIs in May followed by a first home test against Bangladesh since 2010 at Lord's. New Zealand tour in September for three T20s and five ODIs as the teams prepare for the 50-over World Cup in southern Africa in October. The England women also host Bangladesh in September for six white-ball matches.

Target is a medal at LA 2028: Indian women's hockey coach Marijne

SAUMOJYOTI S CHOUDHURY
■ New Delhi

Dutch coach Sjoerd Marijne is aiming for the stars with the Indian women's hockey team, with his biggest goal being to secure a podium finish at the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics — a feat he narrowly missed at the Tokyo Games.

Under Marijne, the Indian women produced their best-ever Olympic performance by finishing a creditable fourth in Tokyo in 2021.

The Dutchman, who coached India from 2017 to 2021, is now looking to go one step further after returning to the role earlier this year.

To achieve that goal, he has enlisted the help of an inspi-

ration speaker to motivate his players, and the move has already yielded encouraging results, with India winning the FIH Nations Cup this year to earn promotion back to the elite FIH Pro League for next season.

"...There is an inspirational speaker, who talks about scaling bigger mountains like Kilimanjaro. Our bigger goal is to get a medal at the 2028 Olympics, and for that we have to work towards getting to our first base camp. Out first base camp was the FIH Nations Cup and qualifying for the World Cup. If you need to reach the top every time you need to reach the base camp first. We are climbing that mountain together and we are reaching for the stars and if you reach for the stars you will fall on the highest mountain," Marijne told PTI in an exclusive interview.

The real star for me is to finish on the podium in 2028. "That is a process, that is



about small steps you are taking, it's about recovery, bringing a good staff together, bringing the right players, mixing talent, mixing seniority with juniors. Everything is about building a culture and every person in that culture needs to be the best version

of themselves." Marijne said his goal was to scale the "Mount Everest" of Indian women's hockey by winning an Olympic medal, and to achieve that, he has sought professional help to strengthen the players' mental resilience and motivation. "I spoke about a climber who summited Mount Everest and Kilimanjaro and his name is Hemant Gupta. I invited him to speak with the team about the challenges he faced and working as a team to climb the Everest." A no-nonsense coach, Marijne has always emphasised building unity and a strong team culture — qualities he felt were missing after his departure following the Tokyo Olympics. (PTI)

The Oval to host 2027 WTC final

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ London

The Oval will host the 2027 World Test Championship final from June 9 to 13, the International Cricket Council announced on Thursday.

England had last year secured the hosting rights for the next three World Test Championship Finals — in 2027, 2029 and 2031 — with home board ECB responsible for selecting the venue for each edition.

All the three WTC finals thus far have also been held in the United Kingdom.

This will be the second time that The Oval will host the WTC final, having previously staged the showpiece



in 2023, when Australia defeated India to lift the mace. With less than a year to go, the current WTC cycle is entering its business end, with nine teams still in the race to secure a place in the final. Australia (87.50 points percentage), having won seven of their eight Tests, sit comfortably at the top of the

standings, followed by defending champions South Africa (75 per cent).

New Zealand (72.22 per cent) remain within striking distance of the Proteas, while Bangladesh (58.33 per cent) have moved firmly into contention after completing a 2-0 sweep of Pakistan in May.

India crush Zimbabwe as Vaibhav shines

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Harare

Wonderkid Vaibhav Sooryavanshi smashed an 18-ball half century in his first innings of substance in international cricket as an all-round India outplayed Zimbabwe by seven wickets in the first T20 of the three match series on Thursday.

Pacer Mayank Yadav made a successful return to international cricket as India restricted Zimbabwe to 125 for seven. India expectedly gunned down the target in 13.2 overs following a typical knock from Sooryavanshi (50 off 19) that included four boundaries and as many sixes.

It was also India's first win under new captain Shreyas

Iyer, who endured a run of six losses in his first assignment in Ireland and England.

Sooryavanshi's much hyped international debut in England earlier this month did not go as per the script but made his familiarity with the venue count.

In his return to the ground where he made a memorable 80-ball 175 in the U-19 World Cup final earlier this year, the youngest to play for India displayed his rare talent that has been acknowledged by the cricketing world.

While Abhishek Sharma (1 off 8) struggled at the other end, Sooryavanshi took down the Zimbabwe attack bit by bit. He began with couple of breathtaking sixes off Richard Ngarava in the second over of



the chase. The first one was a one legged pull shot that sailed over deep square leg before he made a slight room to nonchalantly a dispatch a decent length ball over mid-off.

Blessing Muzarabani, who did not allow Sooryavanshi to free his arm initially, was

also taken to the cleaners in fifth over when the 15-year-old smoked a 90m six down the ground. He brought his fifty right after powerplay and a ball later he was caught at third man off Ngarava.

Following his dismissal, Ishan Kishan (35 off 24) and

captain Shreyas Iyer (28 not out off 24) got the job done comfortably.

Earlier, Mayank Yadav cranked up serious pace from the get go in his first game for India since October 2024. He had opener Brian Bennett (0) caught behind off a peach the very first ball of the match, beating the batter with a hard length ball that straightened slightly to take the outside edge. The on-field umpire did not hear the nick but a confident India got the decision in their favour via DRS.

Mayank, who had a surgery last year following a stress fracture, consistently hit speeds beyond 145 kmph. He targeted the back of a length area and often hurried the batters with his pace.

Sindhu bows out early from China Open

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Changzhou

Indian badminton ace PV Sindhu let slip early advantage to bow out of China Open with a gruelling three-game loss to local favourite and world number four Chen Yufei in the second round on Thursday.

Sindhu lost 21-16, 20-22, 18-21 in the energy-sapping match that lasted close to one and a half hour. The 30-year-old Hyderabad had entered the tournament on a high after winning the Japan Open last week, ending a lengthy title drought. That the match was going to be a closely fought affair was evident in the opening game itself in which Sindhu rallied from 7-



13 to be 16-16. The Indian then reeled off five consecutive points to grab the early advantage.

However, it was Chen's turn to pull off a comeback in the second game as Sindhu frittered away four game points. Chen, who is a

gold-medallist from Tokyo Olympics in 2021, took the game 22-20, clawing back from a 16-20 position.

The deciding third game also went neck-and-neck for most part before Chen broke away at 17-17 to clinch the victory.

Sports ministry extends NSB application deadline

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The formation of the much-awaited National Sports Board (NSB) will take some more time after the Sports Ministry extended the deadline for submission of applications for the selection of its chairman and members by 15 days to August 6.

The original deadline for submission of applications expired on Wednesday.

"It is hereby informed that the last date for submission of online applications has been extended by 15 days' ie. from 22.06.2026 to 06.08.2026 (up to 20:00 Hrs.)," the ministry circular stated.

The appointments in the National Sports Board will be done on the recommendations of a Search-cum-Selection Committee headed by cabinet secretary TV Somanathan.

Olympic bronze-winning former shooter Gagan Narang and weightlifting great N Kunjarani Devi are also in the five-member committee. The other members are Sports Secretary Hari Ranjan Rao, and Indian Olympic Association's (IOA) Executive Council member Lt General (Retd) Harpal Singh.

The candidates would be required to be "from amongst persons of ability, integrity and standing, having knowledge or practical experience in the field of public administration, sports governance, sports law and other related fields." In addition to granting affiliation, the National Sports Board will maintain a roster of the



National Sports Election Panel and a register of affiliate units of the National Sports Bodies. The Board has also been empowered to specify model guidelines or regulations on sports governance. An age cap of 65 has been set for its members. The NSB is being formed under the National Sports Governance Act that was passed in August last year.

Deadline for NST applications extended again: The deadline of applications for appointments to the National Sports Tribunal has been extended for a second time. Originally set at June 18, the deadline was extended till July 18 the first time and has once again been revised to July 25 now. The selection process will be carried out by a Search-cum-Selection Committee headed by the Chief Justice of India or a Supreme Court judge, designated by the CJI.

"The Committee will scrutinise applications and assess candidates based on their qualifications, experience, and suitability for the position. Shortlisted candidates will be invited for personal interaction," the ministry stated.

Olympic countdown clock raises venue timeline questions for Brisbane 2032

JOHN PYE ■ Brisbane

A pesky native bird appeared on the podium almost on cue as organizers prepared to unveil a countdown clock marking six years to go until the 2032 Olympics.

Lord Mayor Adrian Schrinner noted the timely white ibis in his welcoming remarks, joking with the crowd that it wouldn't be an event in Brisbane without the appearance of a "bin chicken," as the bird is colloquially known.

There's a small, humorous push locally for the ibis to become a mascot for the Brisbane Games rather than one of Australia's more widely known native animals such as the kangaroo or the koala. Schrinner didn't miss a beat and the bird moved off before the big digital Omega clock

officially started counting down Thursday in the downtown Queen Street mall. That was a matter of hours after the Games Independent Infrastructure and Coordination Authority published revamped designs for the National Aquatic Center that will host Olympic events.



in construction, even under stress conditions," he said. "I'm very confident that the contingencies are built (in) to allow that to happen."

Liveris said he briefed IOC president Kirsty Coventry as recently as Monday in New York, in the wake of the World Cup final. "We had a long conversation about timelines, venues, sports, and we're confident it's not 6 minutes to midnight," he

said. The International Olympic Committee last year backed the Queensland government's revised venue plan after several false starts, saying the Brisbane Games were "on the right path."

There are still groups opposed to building major sports venues in the downtown parklands, and more general concern over rising costs of staging the Games. GLICA, the coordination

UPT20's multi-city format expands fan reach: GC chief

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Hosting the UPT20 League for the first time in two different cities is a logistical challenge but it offers a chance to reach out to more fans across the State, reckons Chairman of the league's Governing Council Sanjay Kapoor.

The fourth edition of the 24-day UPT20 League will be played in Lucknow and Kanpur from August 14 with Kashi Rudras taking on defending champions Meerut Mavericks in the tournament opener. "Hosting matches in multi-



Chairman of league's Governing Council Sanjay Kapoor

ple cities is a significant milestone for us. While it comes with logistical challenges, it also allows us to take the league closer to the

people and expand its reach across the state," said Kapoor in a statement.

"This year, matches will be played in Lucknow and

Kanpur, while the auction will be held in Agra, which means UPT20 has already connected with three important cities of Uttar Pradesh," he added.

The opening ceremony and the first phase of the league will be held at the Bharat Ratna Shri Atal Bihari Vajpayee Ekana Cricket Stadium in Lucknow.

The tournament will then move to Green Park Stadium in Kanpur, which will host the second half of the season, including the knockout matches and the grand finale. Qualifier 1 and the Eliminator are scheduled to be played on September

3, followed by Qualifier 2 on September 4. The final will be on September 6.

Kapoor said the UPT20 League provides a valuable opportunity for young players to share the dressing room with experienced stars. "Cricket is not just learned through books or coaching sessions; it is learned through conversations, travel, observation, and spending time with experienced players who have performed at the highest level." "UPT20 provides that environment, and it can play a crucial role in shaping the careers of many youngsters," he said.

Australia picks Indian-origin players for MRF Academy



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Melbourne

Indian-origin players Aryan Sharma and Jason Sangha have been named in the Australian men's development squad to train at the MRF Pace Academy next month.

The men's development squad will travel to Chennai from August 1-13 to participate in this year's MRF Academy Program.

The programme will feature two multi-day matches, scheduled for August 5-6 and 10-11 on extremely spin friendly pitches. "The Chennai visit will provide valuable development opportunities for some of Australia's most promising players as part of Cricket Australia's national development pathway," the CA stated. Former Australian captain Tim Paine and Anthony Clark will lead the coaching group of the emerging squad for the MRF Academy Program.

Elias Baez, Miguel rally Atlanta United to 2-2 draw with Charlotte

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Charlotte (US)

Rookie defender Elias Baez and Miguel Almiron scored second-half goals and Atlanta United rallied for a 2-2 draw with Charlotte FC.

Kerwin Vargas staked Charlotte (6-6-4) to a 1-0 lead in the 16th minute on Wednesday night, scoring for the third time this season when Lucas Hoyos blocked but couldn't corral a shot by Archie Goodwin.

Liel Abada used assists from Pep Biel and Ashley Westwood in the 45th minute to score his first goal of the campaign on a header and Charlotte took a 2-0 lead into halftime. It was the seventh assist for Biel and the



sixth for Westwood. Baez scored his first career goal 12 minutes into the second half to get Atlanta United (3-10-3) within a goal.

Tomas Jacobs, another rookie defender, notched his first assist and Fafa Picault col-

lected his second. Almiron tied it 2-all when he scored for the first time this season - unassisted in the 76th minute. Hoyos stopped eight shots on goal for Atlanta United. Kristijan Kahlina finished with four saves for Charlotte.

Scottie seeks to stay sharp in 3M Open debut

DAVE CAMPBELL
■ Blaine (US)

Scottie Scheffler left the British Open with some frustration after another near miss in a major championship and travelled straight to Minnesota for his first appearance in the 3M Open.

A week off after the last major of the season would have made sense for the world's top-ranked player, but Scheffler was focused on keeping his game sharp ahead of the FedEx Cup playoffs — and find some off-the-course respite for him and his supporting cast.

"The people have been tremendous, the fans have been really nice to me so far, and the tournament seems to do a really good job just taking care of everybody,"



Scheffler said on Wednesday after playing a nine-hole pro-am with Minnesota Vikings coach Kevin O'Connell.

"Clubhouse has been good. Food's been really good. Family's taken care of. Caddie's taken care of.

Those are the things at a tournament when everybody around me is getting taken care of as well, it's really easy for us to come and play." Hollis Cagner is happy to hear that. The tournament's director and chief executive officer of

Pro Links Sports has made player hospitality a priority since the 3M Open was added to the PGA Tour schedule in 2019.

From the catered family dinners on the clubhouse patio each night to the inflatables and magicians for the kids, the event at TPC Twin Cities a half-hour's drive north of Minneapolis has become well-regarded by players, even if its calendar placement has limited the star power in the fields.

"People seem to be really thankful that we're here, which is surprising for a golf tournament," Scheffler said. "I was kind of taken aback by how nice people have been." Scheffler's presence has put the tournament on pace for record attendance. (AP)

Hope to see all women boxers win medals at Glasgow CWG: Md Ali Qamar

SUMAN RAY ■ New Delhi

Indian boxing great and former coach Mohammed Ali Qamar believes the country has fielded one of its best ever women's squad at the Glasgow Commonwealth Games and each one of the seven members is capable of coming back with a medal.

Qamar, however, also made it clear that a lot will depend on the draws that the boxers are handed. India has picked a 14-member

squad, comprising seven men and as many women. The boxing competition at the CWG will get underway on Friday.

"Boxing has always won medals in the Commonwealth Games. And even this time, the boxers who are going are very experienced. They have won medals in many competitions. I am sure India will have a good performance in the CWG," Ali, who was the women's head coach for



nearly six years including the Tokyo Olympics, told PTI in an exclusive interaction.

Qamar was the first Indian boxer to win a CWG gold when he became the light fly-

weight champion at the 2002 Manchester Games. A nose injury after that cut short his career and before becoming a coach, he also served as a member of the national selection committee. He is no longer a part of the coaching set up for women, which is headed by Sweden's Santiago Nieva. But having known the boxers and their work ethic, Qamar said he is confident of a strong performance.

"Many boxers that I prepared for the Tokyo Olympics

are going to this Commonwealth Games like Jaismine (Lamboria, 57kg) and Lovlina (Borgohain, 75kg). We had kept Arundhati Choudhary (70kg) as a sparing partner. Priya (60kg) has come in as a senior from a youth group, but now she is doing well. So there is a lot of hope," he observed.

The Arjuna and Dronacharya awardee is keenly looking forward to a strong performance from the seasoned Lovlina. (PTI)

Lovlina Borgohain assures India first medal at CWG

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Glasgow

Lovlina Borgohain assured India of their first medal at the Commonwealth Games after the boxer received a direct entry into the semifinals of the women's 75kg event, which also guaranteed her at least a bronze.

The Tokyo Olympic bronze medallist was handed a first-round bye in



the five-boxer draw, automatically securing a place in the last four and assuring herself a podium finish.